



FIELD MANUAL

VOL. I • MEMBERS EDITION

THE REPAIR PLAYBOOK.

*A complete six-phase, five-round dispute system. Built on FCRA and
FDCPA law. Walk through the work, slow down where it matters,
finish on the other side.*

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BOARD-CERTIFIED CREDIT EDUCATOR

EDITION

2026

WELCOME, COUSIN.

If you are holding this kit, you have already made the decision most people never make. You have decided to stop waiting on someone else to fix it for you, and you have decided to learn the work yourself.

That decision matters. The credit industry is built on the assumption that you will get tired, get confused, or get sold a service you cannot afford. Most people quit halfway. The Cousins who win are the ones who do not stop.

I built this kit so you would not have to guess. Every phase has a purpose. Every letter has a reason. Every legal citation in here is real, accurate, and current. The order matters more than the words, so I am asking you to walk through it the way I designed it. When you do, the system works.

This is not a quick-fix promise. It is a six-to-twelve-month walk. Some accounts will delete on the first round. Others will take all five. Either way, the law is on your side, and the process holds up.

I will be in here with you the whole way. Where the language gets technical, I slow down and explain it. Where you might be tempted to skip a step, I tell you why not. Where you have a real choice to make, I lay both paths out so you can decide for yourself.

This is real credit education. Open door. Pull up a chair.

Shonda Martin♥

FOUNDER, CREDIT ACADEMY

**BEFORE YOU START****THE TRUTH ABOUT THIS PROCESS.**

Understand this upfront and you will finish the journey while others quit halfway. This is the most important page in the kit.

01 NOT ALL ACCOUNTS ARE EQUAL

Some accounts delete quickly because they are newer errors or furnisher mistakes. Others fight back for months because the furnisher has documentation. Medical collections often delete faster than credit card charge-offs. Student loans and mortgages run on different rules entirely. The kit accounts for all of it.

02 YOUR SCORE WILL MOVE

Your score might dip before it rises. That is data shifting, not failure. New negative marks may appear as old ones get removed because the bureaus catch up. Utilization changes can swing your score 20 to 50 points in a single month. None of that means you did anything wrong. The work continues.

03 THEY WILL RESIST

The credit industry profits from keeping negative data on your file. The bureaus have zero incentive to help you. When they stall or send a generic response, that is the system working as designed. This kit counters their standard tactics with strategy that holds up under that pressure.

Their playbook, in plain language. "Verified" letters that confirm nothing. Delayed or vague responses. "Updated" accounts where they tweak a small detail instead of deleting. "Frivolous" claims to dodge their legal obligation. Each round in this kit is built specifically for how they push back.

04 THE TIMELINE REALITY**30****DAYS PER ROUND**

Bureau investigation window under FCRA §611(a)(1)(A).

5-7**WEEKS PER ROUND**

Mailing time both ways added to the response window.

6-12**MONTHS TOTAL**

Full damaged-to-stable journey for a typical file.

A NOTE ON PATIENCE

Real transformation usually shows between months three and nine. Do not expect linear progress. You might see 40-point jumps followed by plateaus. That is not the kit failing. That is the system working.

*Credit repair is progress through correction,
not just removal.*



ORIENTATION

HOW TO USE THIS PLAYBOOK.

Read this once, all the way through, before you start sending anything. Then come back to it as a reference.

01 TWO FRAMEWORKS WORKING TOGETHER

This kit runs on two structures at the same time. **Phases** are the stages of work. You walk through them in order, one before the next, and you only do the work the phase calls for. **Rounds** are the dispute cycles that live inside Phases 4 and 5. Each round is a stronger letter on the same account, and you only move to the next round when the prior one has been answered or has timed out. Both axes are doing different jobs at the same time.

 THE PHASES
STAGES OF WORK

Phase 1 is preparation. Phase 6 is escalation. You move through them in order. The middle phases sometimes run in parallel, but you never skip ahead.

 THE ROUNDS
LETTERS BACK AND FORTH

The dispute cycles inside Phase 4 and Phase 5. Each round tightens the legal pressure. You only escalate when the prior round has been answered or has timed out.

02 THE THREE THINGS THAT MAKE THIS WORK**ORDER****SEQUENCE MATTERS.**

Skip a phase and the next one weakens. The order is not arbitrary. It is the way the law layers up.

**PAPER TRAIL****DOCUMENT EVERYTHING.**

Certified mail, return receipt, tracking numbers. Every letter, every response, every date. This is your evidence file.

**PATIENCE****HOLD THE LINE.**

The 30-day clock starts on the delivery date, not the mailing date. You will be tempted to follow up early. Do not.

03 WHAT'S IN THIS PLAYBOOK

You are holding the complete system. The next pages give you the full Table of Contents, the Phase Map, the 5-Round Strategy, and the Account Type Router. After that, every phase has its own opener page, its own letters with instruction pages, and a clear "what comes next" decision flow at the bottom.

At the back of the Playbook, you will find the Round Tracker for your records, the CFPB filing walkthrough for Phase 6, and a closing word from me.

ONE CRITICAL RULE

Do not file disputes online. The bureaus' online portals waive your right to sue under the FCRA and limit your legal options if they violate your rights. Certified mail with return receipt only. This is not optional.

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BEFORE YOU START • UNDERSTAND THE SYSTEM

PHASES & ROUNDS.

PHASES

STAGES OF WORK.

1

Six stages. Each a different kind of work. You walk through them in order. Finish one. Start the next. Phase 1 reveals which phases your file actually needs.

ROUNDS

LETTERS BACK AND FORTH.

2

A round is a letter. You write to a bureau or furnisher. They write back, or stay silent past 30 days. That exchange is one round. Each new round is a stronger letter on the same account.

HOW THEY FIT TOGETHER

1	PREPARE Pull reports. Audit personal info. Sort accounts. Pick a route.	NO ROUNDS
2	VALIDATE Fresh-collection validation letters under FDCPA §1692g.	NO ROUNDS
3	CLEAN IDENTITY Personal information cleanup. Foundation work for everything that follows.	NO ROUNDS
4	DISPUTE BUREAUS Letters to Equifax, Experian, TransUnion.	R1 Open the dispute R2 Cite the law
5	CHALLENGE FURNISHERS Letters direct to the data furnisher.	R3 Direct demand R4 Violation notice R5 Final notice
6	ESCALATE CFPB, FTC, State AG, attorney. A different lever, not a round.	NO ROUNDS

TRACK EVERY ROUND

Date sent. Date received. Outcome. Next move. Log every back-and-forth on the **Round Tracker** at the back of this Playbook.



THE PHASE MAP

YOUR JOURNEY AT A GLANCE.

Six phases. The work flows in order. Phase 1 is foundation. Phase 6 is escalation. Most people only need three or four phases. A few need all six. You will know which after Phase 1.

PHASE 01

PREPARE

Pull all three official reports. Audit personal information. Identify negatives. Sort everything into four buckets. Choose your route. No letters in this phase.

NO LETTERS • 2-3 HOURS

PHASE 02

VALIDATE

Stop new collections before they stick. Time-sensitive 30-day window for fresh collection notices. Most users skip this phase entirely.

LETTERS 1-4 • 4-6 WEEKS

PHASE 03

CLEAN IDENTITY

Fix personal information at the source and at the bureau. This is the foundation for every dispute that comes after. Skip this and Phase 4 weakens.

LETTERS 5-10 • 30-45 DAYS

PHASE 04

DISPUTE BUREAUS

Round 1 challenges the data. Round 2 challenges the investigation. Most accounts move in this phase. The bureau letters that do the heavy lifting.

LETTERS 11-14 • 60-90 DAYS

PHASE 05

CHALLENGE FURNISHERS

Round 3 demands proof. Round 4 goes direct to the source. Round 5 runs simultaneous pressure on bureau and furnisher. Where the stubborn accounts crack.

LETTERS 15-19 • 60-120 DAYS

PHASE 06

ESCALATE

CFPB complaint. FTC complaint. State Attorney General. Consumer rights attorney consultation. Most cases never reach this phase. Knowing how to use it changes the leverage anyway.

NO NEW LETTERS • 30-60 DAYS

How the phases connect. Phase 1 tells you which phases you need. Phase 2 only matters if you have a fresh collection. Phase 3 must happen before Phase 4. Phase 4 and Phase 5 work the same accounts at increasing pressure. Phase 6 only triggers when 4 and 5 have been exhausted. The order is the strategy.

THE 5-ROUND STRATEGY

HOW THE PRESSURE BUILDS.

You are not sending the same dispute over and over. You are tightening the legal argument each round. Each round builds on the one before it.

The legal foundation. Bureaus and furnishers are required to conduct a *reasonable investigation* of every non-frivolous dispute. Not a generic response. Not an automated code exchange. A real investigation. This strategy exploits the gap between what they are required to do and what they actually do.

1

ROUND 1 • PHASE 4

Challenge the data.

Dispute specific inaccuracies at the bureau level. Balance, status, dates, DOFD, payment history, ownership. Your goal is not deletion yet. Your goal is to put every account on record and force their first response so you have something to push back against.

FCRA §611(a)(1)(A) • §611(a)(5)(A)

2

ROUND 2 • PHASE 4

Challenge the investigation.

The bureau came back saying "verified." Now you challenge the investigation itself. "Verified" is not proof. You are demanding they show you how they verified it. Most disputes go through e-OSCAR, an automated system. No human reviewed your dispute. That is a documented FCRA violation.

FCRA §611(a)(7) • Method of Verification

3

ROUND 3 • PHASE 5

Challenge the proof, or the consistency.

Two paths here. If they gave no method-of-verification details, demand the exact procedure used. If the same account reports differently across the three bureaus, attack the inconsistency directly. You do not need to know which bureau is right. The contradiction itself is the dispute.

FCRA §611(a)(7) • §1681s-2(a)

4

ROUND 4 • PHASE 5**Challenge the source directly.**

Bypass the bureau. Go directly to the company furnishing the data. Collections trigger both FCRA and FDCPA rights. Charge-offs with original creditors trigger FCRA only. Force them to either correct, verify with real documentation, or generate the contradictions you can use against them later.

FCRA §623(a)(8) • FDCPA §1692g • §1692e(8)

5

ROUND 5 • PHASE 5**Force bureau and source to stay consistent.**

Send to the furnisher and the bureau on the same day. Both investigations run simultaneously. The furnisher cannot quietly confirm to the bureau without your direct dispute sitting on their desk. If they tell you one thing and the bureau another, that contradiction is your evidence file.

FCRA §611(a)(1)(A) • §623(a)(8)(E)**WHEN ROUNDS 1-5 COMPLETE WITH NO RESOLUTION**

Phase 6 begins. Present your documented file of specific federal violations to the CFPB, FTC, your state Attorney General, and a consumer rights attorney. FCRA §616 and §617 provide statutory damages up to \$1,000 per violation, plus actual damages, punitive damages, and attorney fees.

ACCOUNT TYPE ROUTER

WHERE DOES YOUR ACCOUNT ENTER?

Find the account type. Read across the row. That is your entry point and your Round 1 opening. Every account type uses the same 5-round system from there.

ACCOUNT TYPE	ENTRY POINT	ROUND 1 OPENING	LEGAL ANGLE
Collection · under 30 days	Phase 2	FDCPA validation demand first. Force the collector to prove they have the right to collect. If they cannot validate within 30 days, they must cease collection activity and reporting.	FCRA + FDCPA
Collection · over 30 days	Phase 4	Bureau accuracy dispute. Focus on Date of First Delinquency. A wrong DOFD keeps the account on past the 7-year legal removal limit. Challenge balance, status, and reporting consistency.	FCRA + FDCPA
Charge-off · OC reporting	Phase 4	Bureau accuracy dispute. Focus on DOFD, balance inflation after charge-off, status accuracy, reporting consistency across all three bureaus.	FCRA only
Charge-off · sold, both reporting	Phase 4 + 5	Dual reporting of the same debt is a violation. Bureau accuracy dispute plus direct dispute to both the original creditor and the collector simultaneously.	FCRA · FDCPA for collector
Late payments	Phase 4	Dispute payment history accuracy. Request full payment history documentation. Challenge any late payment that does not match your records.	FCRA only
Repossession	Phase 4	Dispute deficiency balance accuracy, whether sale proceeds were properly applied, DOFD accuracy, and post-repo balance inflation.	FCRA only
Medical debt	Phase 4	Under \$500 not reported by Equifax, Experian, or TransUnion per their 2022 voluntary policy. Same for paid medical debt and unpaid medical debt under one year old. Dispute any account that	FCRA · bureau policy · state law

ACCOUNT TYPE	ENTRY POINT	ROUND 1 OPENING	LEGAL ANGLE
		violates those policies. State law may add stronger protection in 15+ states.	
Student loan · federal	Phase 4	Dispute payment status, deferment or forbearance reporting, servicer transfer errors. Use FSA ombudsman channel simultaneously.	FCRA · FSA ombudsman
Student loan · private	Phase 4	Same as any furnisher. Dispute balance, status, payment history, servicer reporting accuracy.	FCRA only
Unauthorized hard inquiry	Separate	Written inquiry removal demand sent directly to the creditor who pulled it. Requires proof you did not authorize the pull.	FCRA §604 · permissible purpose
Duplicate account	Phase 4	Dispute both listings simultaneously to all three bureaus. Duplicate reporting of the same account as two separate items is a material inaccuracy.	FCRA §1681s-2(a)
Bankruptcy · public record	Phase 4	Dispute filing date, discharge date, and account statuses post-discharge. Discharged accounts must show zero balance and discharged status.	FCRA §605 · reporting periods

PHASE ONE

PREPARE

Pull, audit, sort, route.

The most important phase, and the one most people skip. Before you send a single letter, you need to know what is on your reports, what is wrong, what type each account is, and which phases you actually need. This phase has no letters. It has a process. Walk it once, and the next 60 pages get easier.

01 WHAT YOU WILL DO

1

Pull all three official reports.

From [AnnualCreditReport.com](https://www.annualcreditreport.com) only. Equifax, Experian, TransUnion. Print or save all three. Online monitoring tools show summaries, not the full record. You need the full record.

2

Audit your personal information first.

Before touching accounts, go line by line through the Personal Information section on all three reports. Bureaus use this section to verify accounts. Clutter here makes everything harder later.

3

Identify and highlight every negative account.

Collections, charge-offs, 90+ day lates, repossessions, foreclosures, past-due balances, duplicates, accounts you do not recognize. Highlight them. Do not try to fix anything yet. Evidence-gathering only.

4

Sort everything into the four buckets.

Every item on your report goes into exactly one of four categories. The result tells you which phases you need and which you can skip.

1

PHASE 1 • STEP 1

PULL ALL THREE OFFICIAL REPORTS.

Before a surgeon operates, they review the X-rays. Same applies here. You need the full picture from all three bureaus before you can plan a single move.

01 WHERE TO PULL FROM

[AnnualCreditReport.com](https://www.annualcreditreport.com) only. This is the federally-mandated free source for your full official reports. No credit card required. No paid subscription needed. Free for every consumer, every week.

Do not use Credit Karma, your bank's monitoring tool, or the Experian app for this step. Those show summaries and basic information. They do not show the full reporting detail you need to dispute accurately.

WHAT ABOUT THE CREDIT ACADEMY SMARTCREDIT PULL?

[SmartCredit](#) (or your Credit Academy 3B monitoring) is the right tool for ongoing monitoring once you start sending letters. For the foundation pull at the very start, the official [AnnualCreditReport.com](https://www.annualcreditreport.com) download is what you save and reference. Use both for what they are best at.

02 AFTER YOU PULL

Save all three reports to a secure folder on your computer. Print a hard copy of each one to mark up by hand as you audit. Highlighter, pen, sticky tabs. The physical markup process is part of the work.

Set a calendar reminder for 90 days from today and another for 180 days. You will pull updated reports at each of those checkpoints to track what has changed.

03 WHAT YOU ARE LOOKING AT

Each report has five main sections. Knowing what each one does helps you read it strategically.

**PERSONAL
INFORMATION**

Name, addresses, date of birth, SSN, employer history. **Errors here cause disputes to fail.** Reviewed and corrected in Phase 3.

ACCOUNT HISTORY

Every credit account you have or have had. Each tradeline shows the creditor, account number, type, status, balance, credit limit, and payment history.

COLLECTIONS

Accounts sent to third-party debt collectors. Often reported by the collection agency *and* may still appear under the original creditor's tradeline. Check for duplicates.

PUBLIC RECORDS

Bankruptcies. Tax liens and judgments were removed from credit reports for most bureaus in 2017–2018, so you should not see those.

INQUIRIES

A record of who pulled your credit. Hard inquiries from credit applications stay 2 years and may affect score. Soft inquiries from background checks and pre-approvals do not affect score.

2

PHASE 1 • STEP 2

AUDIT YOUR PERSONAL INFORMATION.

Foundation work. Bureaus use this section to verify whether an account belongs to you. If your foundation is shaky, every dispute that comes after is weaker.

Why this comes first. If your report has old addresses, name variations, or wrong employers, a furnisher can use that information to confirm an account by matching it. The cleaner your personal information, the less the bureaus have to work with when they try to verify accounts you are disputing.

01 PERSONAL INFORMATION AUDIT CHECKLIST

Grab a highlighter. On all three reports, mark anything that is not completely up to date.

NAMES

Identify any misspellings. Mark any name variations or names that do not belong to you. Maiden names you no longer use. Suffixes that should not be there. Initials that are wrong.

ADDRESSES

Highlight any address where you have not lived for over two years. Highlight addresses you do not recognize at all. Highlight typos or wrong unit numbers.

EMPLOYERS

Mark employers you never worked for. Mark employers from more than four years ago. Mark misspellings of correct employers.

DATE OF BIRTH

Verify the date is exactly correct. Even a one-digit error here is a high-priority dispute. Goes to Letter 10, not the standard PI letter.

SOCIAL SECURITY NUMBER

Verify every digit shown. SSN errors cause every later phase to fail identity verification. Goes to Letter 10 immediately.

MIXED-FILE WARNING

If the PI section shows information that belongs to a relative, a stranger, or someone with a similar name (a Jr/Sr issue, a similar SSN, a family member), you have a potential mixed file. That goes to Letter 8 and gets handled before standard PI cleanup.

3

PHASE 1 • STEP 3

IDENTIFY THE NEGATIVES.

A negative account is anything dragging your score down or signaling risk to a future lender. Highlight every account that fits any of these definitions. Do not try to fix anything yet.

01 WHAT COUNTS AS NEGATIVE**Collection**

Medical, utility, credit card, old phone bills, any third-party debt collector listed. If the status says "Collection" anywhere, highlight it.

Charge-Off

"Charged Off," "Profit and Loss Write-Off," "Bad Debt," or "Transferred to Recovery." Negative even if the balance is \$0. Highlight it.

Serious Lates

90 days late or more. Some lenders treat this as a charge-off equivalent even if the account is now current. Highlight it.

Repossession

Or foreclosure. Even if it happened years ago. Highlight it.

Past-Due Balance

If the "Amount Past Due" field shows anything other than \$0 on an open account, highlight it.

Duplicate

Same debt appearing once under the original creditor and again under a collection agency. Highlight both. Address the duplication later.

Unrecognized

Accounts you do not recognize. Highlight and mark with a question mark. Goes to Letter 8 (mixed file) or identity theft track.

02 HIGH-VALUE ERRORS WORTH DISPUTING

HIGH-VALUE TARGETS

- Date of First Delinquency (DOFD)
- Balance discrepancies
- Account status conflicts
- Payment history accuracy
- Duplicate reporting
- Inconsistencies across bureaus

LOWER PRIORITY

- Cosmetic spelling issues
- Old data without impact
- Minor address typos that match correctly

Do not waste a dispute round on these unless you have run out of higher-priority targets.

Strategic disputing is not about disputing everything. The goal is to target the data points that are hardest to verify and most damaging if wrong. Pick your strongest evidence first. Build your file methodically.

SORT, THEN ROUTE.

Every item on your report goes into exactly one of four buckets. Once you have sorted, your route through the rest of the kit becomes obvious.

01 THE FOUR BUCKETS**BUCKET 1****LEAVE IT**

Accurate, verified, yours, and reporting correctly. No action needed. Note it and move on.

BUCKET 2**INVESTIGATE**

Not sure if it is accurate. Needs more research before disputing. Pull old statements, dig through emails, check your records.

BUCKET 3**DISPUTE-READY**

Clearly wrong, unverifiable, or inaccurate. Goes into your dispute rounds in Phase 4 and Phase 5.

BUCKET 4**NEW COLLECTION**

Under 30 days old, or just received a notice. Time-sensitive. Goes to Phase 2 immediately.

02 FIND YOUR ROUTE

Where you go next depends on what you have. Find the situation that fits, then follow the route.

NEW COLLECTIONS + OLD NEGATIVES**MOST COMMON**

Both fresh collections under 30 days *and* older charge-offs or collections.

Phase 2 → **Phase 3** in parallel, then **Phase 4** → **Phase 5**

OLD NEGATIVES ONLY**COMMON**

All collections and charge-offs are over 30 days old. No fresh notices anywhere.

~~Skip Phase 2~~ → **Phase 3** → **Phase 4** → **Phase 5**

MIXED FILE OR IDENTITY THEFT**SPECIAL HANDLING**

Accounts that are not yours. Names that are not yours. Addresses you have never lived at.

Letter 8 first → Identity theft? File at [IdentityTheft.gov](https://www.IdentityTheft.gov) before continuing

THIN FILE, NO NEGATIVES

BUILDING TRACK

Nothing negative to dispute. Just not enough accounts or history.

This kit is for repair work. The Credit Academy build content covers your situation. Tour the community for the build framework.

BUYING A HOME IN 90 DAYS

URGENT

Your approach changes significantly when you have a hard mortgage deadline. The DIY timeline is 6 to 12 months. If you have less than 90 days, you may need rapid rescore strategy through your loan officer plus targeted disputing on only the highest-impact items. Consider scheduling a Credit Academy VIP consultation.

YOU FINISHED PHASE 1

You now know what is on your reports, what is wrong, what type each negative is, and which phases you need. The next pages walk you through whichever phases your route includes. If you do not need a phase, skip past it. The kit is built so you can.

PHASE TWO

VALIDATE

Stop new collections before they stick.

Time-sensitive phase. The FDCPA gives you a 30-day window from the date of the collector's first contact to demand validation of the debt. Collectors often cannot produce proper validation, especially on bulk-purchased debt. Sending a validation letter inside that window can stop a collection from ever appearing on your report.

01 WHEN YOU NEED PHASE 2

Use Phase 2 if any of these apply:

- ☐ **Fresh collection under 30 days.** You received a collection notice in the mail recently or a new collection just appeared on your report.
- ☐ **Pending collection.** You received a notice but the account has not yet appeared on your credit report.
- ☐ **No prior notice.** A collection appeared on your credit report but you never received the initial written notice the FDCPA requires.

WHEN TO SKIP THIS PHASE

All your collections are older than one year and you received written notice when they were new. You have already paid or worked directly with the collector. You do not have any new or pending collection accounts. If any of these are true for every collection on your file, jump to Phase 3.

02 THE 4 LETTERS IN THIS PHASE

LETTER 1 • INITIAL VALIDATION

Send within 30 days of first collector contact.
The opening move.

LETTER 2 • VALIDATION FOLLOW-UP

30+ days after Letter 1 with no response.
Demand for cease and removal.

LETTER 3 · INADEQUATE VALIDATION

They responded, but their documentation is incomplete or insufficient.

LETTER 4 · VALIDATION BRIDGE

They sent full documents, but the documents themselves contain errors.

03 CRITICAL FDCPA REMINDERS

The FDCPA protects you from collector abuse. Use these rights specifically:

- ☐ Under FDCPA §1692g, the collector must validate the debt upon written request.
- ☐ If they cannot validate within 30 days of your request, they must cease all collection activity.
- ☐ Collection activity includes credit reporting. They cannot continue reporting an unvalidated debt.
- ☐ Generic "verified as accurate" letters do not legally count as validation.

WHAT TO SEND TO A COLLECTOR VS. A BUREAU

Collectors get only your full name and the last 4 digits of your SSN. Never send a collector your full SSN, your driver's license, your Social Security card, your full date of birth, or address verification documents. Bureaus get more documentation. Collectors do not. Different parties, different rules.

1

PHASE 2 · VALIDATION

INITIAL DEBT VALIDATION REQUEST

USE WITHIN
30 DAYS ONLY

USE THIS LETTER WHEN

- You received a collection notice in the last 30 days
- A new collection just appeared on your report with no prior notice
- A collector contacted you for the first time by phone or mail

DO NOT USE THIS LETTER

If the collection is older than 30 days from your first contact with that collector. Skip to Phase 4 for older collections. The 30-day FDCPA validation window has closed and a different strategy applies.

AFTER YOU SEND IT

Set a 30-day calendar reminder. Do not call them. Do not write again until the 30-day window closes. Watch your credit monitoring for any new reporting activity. The clock starts on the delivery date on your certified mail return receipt, not the day you mailed it.

Collection notice received within 30 days

↓

SEND LETTER 1 to collection agency disputes department

↓

Wait 30 days from delivery date

↓

No response → Letter 2

Inadequate response → Letter 3

Full response with errors → Letter 4

Full clean response with no errors → Move to Phase 4

[Your Full Name]

[Your Address]

[City, State, ZIP Code]

Date: [Insert Date]

Via Certified Mail · Return Receipt Requested

[Collection Agency Name]

[Disputes Department Address]

[City, State, ZIP Code]

Re: Request for Debt Validation

Account Number: [Insert Account Number if Provided]

To Whom It May Concern,

This letter is being sent in response to a notice I received from your agency regarding the above-referenced account. Pursuant to the Fair Debt Collection Practices Act, 15 U.S.C. §1692g, I am exercising my right to request validation of this alleged debt.

I am not refusing to pay. I am requesting that you provide proper validation of the debt before I will discuss this matter further. Until validation is provided, you are required to cease all collection activity, including but not limited to credit reporting.

I am specifically requesting the following:

- ☐ The original signed contract or credit agreement establishing my legal obligation to pay this debt
- ☐ A complete payment history from the original creditor, including all charges, payments, and any interest or fee calculations
- ☐ Documentation proving your legal authority to collect this specific debt — a specific assignment or bill of sale tied to this account, not a bulk purchase agreement
- ☐ Verification of the exact amount claimed, with a full breakdown of principal, interest, and any fees
- ☐ The name and address of the original creditor if different from your agency

Under FDCPA §1692g(b), if you cannot provide proper validation within 30 days of receipt of this letter, you are required to cease all collection activity on this account, including any credit reporting.

A generic "verified as accurate" statement, a printout without original creditor documentation, or a partial account summary will not satisfy your obligations under federal law.

My identifying information:

Last 4 digits of SSN: [XXXX]

Sincerely,

[Your Printed Name]

CREDIT ACADEMY

Letter 1 · Initial Debt Validation Request

shondamartin.com

2

PHASE 2 · VALIDATION

VALIDATION FOLLOW-UP · NO RESPONSE

AFTER DAY 30
ONLY

USE THIS LETTER WHEN

- It has been 30 or more days since the collector received Letter 1
- You have your certified mail return receipt confirming the delivery date
- They have not responded at all

DO NOT SEND BEFORE 30 DAYS HAVE PASSED

The clock starts on the delivery date shown on your return receipt, not the date you mailed it. Sending too early gives them grounds to ignore the letter as premature.

AFTER YOU SEND IT

Give them 15 days. If they delete the account from your reports, you are done with this collection. Monitor the file. If they still do not respond, go to Phase 6 and file a CFPB complaint immediately. Their silence after two notices is a documented FDCPA violation.

30 days passed since Letter 1 delivery

↓

SEND LETTER 2 to same collection agency

↓

Wait 15 days

↓

Account deleted → Done. Monitor your reports.

Still no response → Phase 6 (CFPB complaint)

They respond now → Treat response per Letter 3 or 4 logic

[Your Full Name]

[Your Address]

[City, State, ZIP Code]

Date: [Insert Date]

Via Certified Mail · Return Receipt Requested

[Collection Agency Name]

[Disputes Department Address]

[City, State, ZIP Code]

Re: Failure to Validate Debt — Demand for Cessation of Collection Activity and Removal

Account Number: [Insert Account Number if Provided]

To Whom It May Concern,

On [date of Letter 1], I sent a certified letter requesting validation of the above-referenced debt under the Fair Debt Collection Practices Act, 15 U.S.C. §1692g. According to my certified mail records, you received that request on [delivery date]. I have enclosed a copy of the certified mail delivery confirmation.

To date, you have failed to provide proper validation within the required timeframe.

Your failure to validate this debt within 30 days means you must:

1. Immediately cease all collection activity on this account
2. Remove this account from all credit reporting agencies — Equifax, Experian, and TransUnion
3. Provide written confirmation that this account has been deleted from my credit reports
4. Confirm in writing that all collection activity has permanently ceased

Under the FDCPA, you cannot continue collection efforts or credit reporting on a debt you have failed to validate. Continued collection activity or reporting after a failure to validate constitutes a violation of federal law.

FDCPA §1692k provides for statutory damages up to \$1,000 per violation, plus actual damages and attorney fees. Continued reporting on this unvalidated debt also constitutes a violation of the Fair Credit Reporting Act, 15 U.S.C. §1681s-2(a), which prohibits furnishers from reporting information they know or have reason to believe is inaccurate.

I am retaining all documentation of this correspondence. This is my final communication on this matter before escalating to the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau and consultation with a consumer rights attorney.

CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY

My identifying information:

Last 4 digits of SSN: [XXXX]

Sincerely,

[Your Printed Name]

CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY

Enclosure: Copy of Letter 1 certified mail delivery confirmation

CREDIT ACADEMY

Letter 2 · Validation Follow-Up · No Response

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3

PHASE 2 · VALIDATION

INADEQUATE VALIDATION RESPONSE

WHEN RESPONSE
IS INCOMPLETE

USE THIS LETTER WHEN

- The collector responded to Letter 1 but their response is incomplete
- They sent a generic "verified" statement with no actual documentation
- They are missing any required item: original signed contract, full payment history, proof of legal ownership, or itemized balance breakdown

THIS IS DIFFERENT FROM "NO RESPONSE"

They responded. But what they sent does not legally count as validation under FDCPA §1692g. This letter calls out exactly what is missing, item by item. Attach a copy of their inadequate response to this letter so the record is preserved.

AFTER YOU SEND IT

Give them 15 days. If they send complete documents and you find errors in them, go to Letter 4. If they still cannot validate properly, go to Phase 6 and file a CFPB complaint immediately. A second failure to validate after a specific written demand is a documented FDCPA violation.

Collector responded with insufficient documentation

↓

Document exactly what is missing

↓

SEND LETTER 3 with a copy of their response attached

↓

Wait 15 days

↓

Account deleted → Done. Monitor.

Full documents sent with errors → Letter 4

Still inadequate → Phase 6 (CFPB complaint)

[Your Full Name]

[Your Address]

[City, State, ZIP Code]

Date: [Insert Date]

Via Certified Mail · Return Receipt Requested

[Collection Agency Name]

[Disputes Department Address]

[City, State, ZIP Code]

Re: Dispute of Inadequate Debt Validation Response

Account Number: [Insert Account Number if Provided]

To Whom It May Concern,

On [date of Letter 1], I submitted a written request for debt validation pursuant to my rights under the Fair Debt Collection Practices Act, 15 U.S.C. §1692g. You received this request on [certified mail delivery date], as confirmed by my certified mail records.

On [date of their response], you provided a response. I have reviewed this response and it does not constitute proper validation under federal law.

Specifically, your response failed to include the following required documentation:

- ☐ A copy of the original signed contract or agreement establishing my legal obligation to pay this debt
- ☐ A complete payment history from the original creditor, including all charges, payments, and interest calculations
- ☐ Documentation proving your legal authority to collect this specific debt — a specific bill of sale or assignment, not a bulk purchase agreement
- ☐ Verification of the exact amount claimed, including a full breakdown of principal, interest, and fees
- ☐ The name and address of the original creditor if different from your agency

A generic verification statement, a printout without original creditor documentation, or a partial account summary does not satisfy your obligations under FDCPA §1692g(b).

Until you provide complete and proper validation:

1. You must immediately cease all collection activity on this account
2. You must not report, update, or verify this account with any consumer reporting agency
3. You must not take any legal action regarding this account

CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY

Please respond within 15 days of receipt of this letter with the specific documentation listed above. If you are unable to provide proper validation, I expect written confirmation that this account has been closed and deleted from all consumer reporting agencies.

I am retaining all correspondence, including your prior response, as documentation of this dispute. A copy of your prior response is enclosed with this letter for the record.

CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY

My identifying information:

Last 4 digits of SSN: [XXXX]

Sincerely,

[Your Printed Name]

CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY

Enclosure: Copy of your prior response dated [date]

4

PHASE 2 · VALIDATION

VALIDATION BRIDGE · ERRORS IN THEIR DOCUMENTS

BRIDGE FROM
PHASE 2 TO PHASE 4

USE THIS LETTER WHEN

- The collector responded with what appears to be full documentation
- After reviewing their documents, you found one or more errors
- Errors include wrong DOFD, mismatched balance, account number inconsistencies, missing signature pages, unclear chain of custody, or dates that do not align

This letter is your bridge. It does not end Phase 2 by itself. It documents that even their "validation" contains inaccuracies, then connects you forward into Phase 4 with that documented evidence as ammunition for your bureau dispute.

AFTER YOU SEND IT

Move to Phase 4. You now have documented evidence that the collector's own validation documents contain errors. This is much stronger ammunition than a generic dispute. Reference this letter and the errors it identifies in your Phase 4 bureau letters.

```
Collector sent full validation documents
↓
Audit their documents for errors
↓
SEND LETTER 4 documenting every error found
↓
Move to Phase 4 with this letter as evidence
```

[Your Full Name]

[Your Address]

[City, State, ZIP Code]

Date: [Insert Date]

Via Certified Mail · Return Receipt Requested

[Collection Agency Name]

[Disputes Department Address]

[City, State, ZIP Code]

Re: Dispute of Inaccuracies in Validation Response

Account Number: [Insert Account Number if Provided]

To Whom It May Concern,

On [date of Letter 1], I submitted a request for debt validation pursuant to FDCPA 15 U.S.C. §1692g. On [date of their response], you provided documentation in response to that request.

I have reviewed the documentation. While I acknowledge receipt of your response, I am formally disputing the accuracy of the information contained within those documents based on the following specific discrepancies. Check all that apply.

☐ **Date of First Delinquency Discrepancy**

Your documents reflect a DOFD of [their date]. My records indicate the actual date of first delinquency was [correct date]. This is a material inaccuracy that directly affects the legal reporting timeline under FCRA §605(a)(4).

☐ **Balance Inaccuracy**

The balance you are claiming (\$[amount]) does not match the balance at the time of the original account closure or charge-off. No documentation you provided accounts for this discrepancy.

☐ **Chain of Ownership Gap**

The bill of sale or assignment you provided does not specifically reference this account by account number. A bulk purchase agreement is not sufficient documentation of your legal authority to collect this specific debt.

☐ **Signature Discrepancy**

The original agreement you provided does not bear my signature, or the signature shown does not match my signature on file.

☐ **Payment History Inconsistency**

The payment history you provided contains gaps, unexplained charges, or dates inconsistent with other documentation in your response.

☐ **Other**

[Describe the specific discrepancy]

This letter constitutes formal notice that I dispute the accuracy of the information you have been reporting and intend to report regarding this account. I am also providing notice that I will be exercising my rights under the Fair Credit Reporting Act to dispute this account directly with the consumer reporting agencies, and I will share this correspondence and your documentation as part of that process.

You are on notice that the documentation you have provided contains the inaccuracies identified above. Continued reporting using inaccurate information constitutes a violation of FCRA §1681s-2(a).

My identifying information:

Last 4 digits of SSN: [XXXX]

Sincerely,

[Your Printed Name]

PHASE THREE

CLEAN IDENTITY

Fix the foundation before you fight.

The phase that makes every later phase work. Bureaus use the personal information section to verify whether an account belongs to you. If your report is cluttered with old addresses, name variations, or wrong employers, a furnisher can confirm an account by matching it to that information. Clean this first. Then dispute.

01 WHEN YOU NEED PHASE 3

Use Phase 3 if any of these appear on your reports:

- ☐ Name variations or misspellings
- ☐ Old addresses you no longer live at
- ☐ Outdated employer information
- ☐ Incorrect date of birth
- ☐ Incorrect Social Security number digits
- ☐ Duplicate personal information entries
- ☐ Information that may belong to a relative or stranger (mixed file)

PHASE 3 MUST COME BEFORE PHASE 4

Bureaus rely on the personal information section to "verify" whether an account is yours. If you go straight to disputing accounts without cleaning your PI first, the bureau has more material to use against your dispute. Clean foundation first. Always.

02 THE 6 LETTERS IN THIS PHASE

LETTER 5 · CREDITOR PI UPDATE

Tell your active creditors to update *their* records first. They feed the bureaus.

LETTER 6 · BUREAU PI DISPUTE

Send to each bureau separately. Wrong names, addresses, employers, DOB.

LETTER 7 · BUREAU PI FOLLOW-UP

When a bureau ignores Letter 6 for 30+ days. Demand and document.

LETTER 8 · MIXED FILE / IDENTITY THEFT

Information belonging to a relative, stranger, or theft victim.

LETTER 9 · PI VERIFICATION DEMAND

When the bureau says "verified" but the wrong PI is still showing.

LETTER 10 · SSN / DOB URGENT CORRECTION

Highest priority. The only letter where you send a copy of your SS card.

THE ORDER MATTERS HERE TOO

Send Letter 5 first to your active creditors so the source of your reporting gets corrected. Wait one full reporting cycle (about 30 days). Then send Letter 6 to each bureau. Otherwise the bureaus will just re-add what the creditors keep reporting.

5

PHASE 3 · CLEAN IDENTITY

CREDITOR PERSONAL INFO UPDATEFIRST IN PHASE 3.
SEND BEFORE LETTER 6.**USE THIS LETTER WHEN**

- Your open accounts are still reporting an old address to the bureaus
- An active creditor has wrong personal information on file (name spelling, address, phone)
- You have moved and need creditors updated before you start disputing the bureaus

SEND THIS BEFORE LETTER 6

If your creditors keep reporting old addresses, the bureaus will re-add them every reporting cycle no matter how many times you dispute. Fix the source first. This single discipline is what separates a clean PI cleanup from one that keeps backsliding.

AFTER YOU SEND IT

Wait one full reporting cycle, about 30 days, before moving to Letter 6. Send a copy of Letter 5 to each active creditor that has incorrect information. Each one needs its own envelope and certified mail receipt.

PI errors identified in Phase 1

↓

SEND LETTER 5 to each active creditor with incorrect info

↓

Wait one full reporting cycle (30 days)

↓

Pull updated reports

↓

Creditor info corrected → Move to Letter 6 (bureaus)

Creditor info still wrong → Resend Letter 5 with second notice language

[Your Full Legal Name]

[Your Current Address]

[City, State, ZIP Code]

Date: [Insert Date]

Via Certified Mail · Return Receipt Requested

[Creditor Name]

[Customer Service or Records Department Address]

[City, State, ZIP Code]

Re: Account Information Update Request

Account Number: [Account Number]

To Whom It May Concern,

I am writing to formally request an update to the personal information associated with my account in your records. I want to ensure that the information you report to all three consumer reporting agencies — Equifax, Experian, and TransUnion — accurately reflects my current and correct identifying information.

My correct current information:

Full Legal Name: [Full Legal Name as it appears on your government ID]

Current Address: [Full Street Address, City, State, ZIP]

Date of Birth: [MM/DD/YYYY]

Last 4 of SSN: [XXXX]

Please update your account records to reflect this information and report it to all consumer reporting agencies in your next regularly scheduled reporting cycle.

Please also remove any outdated personal information associated with my account that does not reflect what is listed above:

Previous Address(es) to Remove: [List old addresses, or write "None to specify"]

Name Variations to Remove: [List any, or write "N/A"]

Other Outdated Information: [Old employer, phone, or write "N/A"]

I have enclosed a copy of my government-issued photo ID and a current utility bill or bank statement confirming my address as supporting documentation.

Please provide written confirmation that this update has been made to my account record and will be reflected in your next reporting cycle to all three major consumer reporting agencies. Continued reporting of inaccurate personal information constitutes a violation of FCRA §623(a)(2), which requires furnishers to correct and update inaccurate information.

I am retaining this correspondence as documentation of my request.

Respectfully,

[Your Printed Name]

Enclosures:

- ☐ Government-issued photo ID (copy)
- ☐ Current utility bill or bank statement confirming address (copy)

CREDIT ACADEMY

Letter 5 · Creditor Personal Information Update

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PHASE 3 · CLEAN IDENTITY

BUREAU PERSONAL INFORMATION DISPUTE

AFTER LETTER 5.
ONE PER BUREAU.

USE THIS LETTER WHEN

- A bureau is showing wrong name variations, old addresses, wrong employer, or incorrect date of birth
- You have already sent Letter 5 to your active creditors and waited 30 days
- The error is NOT an SSN or date of birth mismatch — those go to Letter 10 instead

ONE LETTER PER BUREAU

Send a separate envelope to Equifax, Experian, and TransUnion. Each bureau needs its own letter and its own certified mail receipt. One letter does not fix all three. They are separate companies with separate files on you.

AFTER YOU SEND IT

Wait 30 days from the delivery date on each return receipt. Pull your reports and check what changed. If the errors are corrected, you are ready for Phase 4. If the bureau ignored you, go to Letter 7. If they responded "verified" but the wrong info is still there, go to Letter 9.

Letter 5 sent and 30 days passed

↓

SEND LETTER 6 to Equifax, Experian, and TransUnion separately

↓

Wait 30 days from each delivery date

↓

Pull updated reports

↓

PI corrected → Move to Phase 4

No response → Letter 7 (follow-up)

"Verified" but still wrong → Letter 9 (MOV demand)

[Your Full Legal Name]

[Your Current Address]

[City, State, ZIP Code]

Date: [Insert Date]

Via Certified Mail · Return Receipt Requested

[Credit Bureau Name]

[Credit Bureau Address]

[City, State, ZIP Code]

Re: Formal Dispute of Inaccurate Personal Information on Consumer Report

To Whom It May Concern,

I am writing to formally dispute inaccurate personal information currently appearing in my consumer file. The information listed below does not accurately reflect my identity and must be investigated and corrected pursuant to my rights under the Fair Credit Reporting Act.

My correct identifying information:

Full Legal Name: [Name]

Current Address: [Address]

Date of Birth: [DOB]

Last 4 of SSN: [XXXX]

I am requesting that you remove ALL inaccurate personal information from my file, including any name variations, misspellings, and any address other than the one listed above. The following information is currently listed incorrectly and must be corrected or removed:

☐ **Name Variation**

Listed as [wrong name]. My correct legal name is [correct name].

☐ **Wrong Address**

Listed as [wrong address]. I have never resided at this address. My correct current address is shown above.

☐ **Wrong Employer**

Listed as [wrong employer]. My current employer is [correct employer].

☐ **Other Personal Information Error**

CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY

[Describe specifically]

Under FCRA §611(a)(7), I am also requesting the method of verification used to confirm any of the information I am disputing, including the name and contact information of any furnisher or third party contacted during this investigation. Please provide this information along with your written response.

CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY

You are required by law to complete your investigation and provide written results within 30 days of receipt of this letter under FCRA §611(a)(1)(A). Failure to investigate or respond within that timeframe is a violation of federal law.

I have enclosed copies of my government-issued ID and most recent utility bill to verify my identity.

My identifying information:

Last 4 digits of SSN: [XXXX]

CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY

Sincerely,

[Your Printed Name]

Enclosures:

- ☐ Government-issued photo ID
- ☐ Proof of current address

7

PHASE 3 · CLEAN IDENTITY

BUREAU PI FOLLOW-UP · FAILURE TO INVESTIGATEDAY 31+
AFTER LETTER 6**USE THIS LETTER WHEN**

- It has been 30 or more days since the bureau received Letter 6
- You have your certified mail return receipt confirming the delivery date
- The bureau has not responded and your report has not changed

WAIT THE FULL 30 DAYS FIRST

Do not send this letter early. The clock starts on the delivery date on your return receipt, not the day you mailed it. Attach a copy of Letter 6 AND your delivery receipt to this follow-up letter so the record is preserved.

AFTER YOU SEND IT

Give them 15 days. If they correct the PI, move on to Phase 4. If they still ignore you, go to Phase 6 and file a CFPB complaint. Failure to respond to a written dispute within 30 days is a documented FCRA violation under §611(a)(1)(A).

30 days passed since Letter 6 delivery

↓

SEND LETTER 7 with copies of Letter 6 + delivery receipt attached

↓

Wait 15 days

↓

PI corrected → Move to Phase 4

No response → Phase 6 (CFPB complaint)

[Your Full Legal Name]

[Your Current Address]

[City, State, ZIP Code]

Date: [Insert Date]

Via Certified Mail · Return Receipt Requested

[Credit Bureau Name]

[Credit Bureau Address]

[City, State, ZIP Code]

Re: Second Notice — Failure to Investigate Personal Information Dispute

Original Dispute Date: [Date of Letter 6]

To Whom It May Concern,

On [date], I submitted a formal written dispute regarding inaccurate personal information on my consumer report. You received that dispute on [delivery date], as confirmed by my certified mail return receipt, which I have enclosed.

To date, you have failed to provide any written response or make any correction to my report. Your failure to investigate and respond within 30 days is a direct violation of the Fair Credit Reporting Act §611(a)(1)(A), which requires consumer reporting agencies to conduct a reasonable investigation within 30 days of receiving a written dispute.

I am formally demanding the following:

1. An immediate investigation into the disputed personal information listed in my original letter
2. Written confirmation of the results of that investigation within 15 days of receipt of this letter
3. Removal of all inaccurate personal information that cannot be verified through your investigation

The disputed items are: [List each item exactly as listed in Letter 6, separated by commas]

Be advised that continued failure to respond or investigate entitles me to pursue remedies under FCRA §616 (willful noncompliance) and §617 (negligent noncompliance), which provide for actual damages, statutory damages, punitive damages, and attorney fees.

I am also prepared to file a formal complaint with the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau documenting your failure to meet your legal obligations under federal law.

Please govern yourself accordingly.

CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY

My identifying information:

Last 4 digits of SSN: [XXXX]

Sincerely,

[Your Printed Name]

CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY

Enclosures:

- ☐ Copy of original dispute letter (Letter 6)
- ☐ Certified mail delivery confirmation

CREDIT ACADEMY

Letter 7 · Bureau PI Follow-Up

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PHASE 3 · CLEAN IDENTITY

MIXED FILE OR IDENTITY THEFT

SPECIAL HANDLING.
STOP AND ASSESS.

USE THIS LETTER WHEN

- Someone else's name, address, or accounts are appearing on your report
- You share a name with a family member (Jr/Sr issue, similar first/last names)
- You see addresses you have never lived at in your personal information section
- Accounts you never opened are showing on your report

STOP BEFORE SENDING. DETERMINE WHICH SITUATION APPLIES.

MIXED FILE:

Another person's information is on your report due to a bureau error. Most common with Jr/Sr names, family members who share a name, or similar Social Security numbers. → This letter handles it.

IDENTITY THEFT:

Accounts you never opened are on your report. Someone used your information without authorization. → File at [IdentityTheft.gov](https://www.identitytheft.gov) first, get your FTC report number, then add it to this letter before sending.

03 IF IDENTITY THEFT APPLIES

Before sending this letter, complete these three steps:

1. Go to [IdentityTheft.gov](https://www.identitytheft.gov) and complete the guided FTC report
2. Save your FTC report number — it has the format IDT-XXXX-XXXX
3. Return to this letter, add your FTC report number to the body, then send

Your FTC report number upgrades your dispute from a standard request to a federal fraud claim. The bureaus must block the disputed information per FCRA §605B once an FTC identity theft report is filed. Do not skip this step.

AFTER YOU SEND IT

Give 30 days. If unresolved, file a CFPB complaint. Mixed-file errors are one of the most clearly documented FCRA violations because the bureau has no legal basis to report another person's information on your file.

[Your Full Legal Name]

[Your Current Address]

[City, State, ZIP Code]

Date: [Insert Date]

Via Certified Mail · Return Receipt Requested

[Credit Bureau Name]

[Credit Bureau Address]

[City, State, ZIP Code]

Re: Mixed / Merged Credit File — Demand for Investigation and Removal

Report Number: [Insert Credit Report Number]

FTC Report Number (if identity theft): [IDT-XXXX-XXXX or write N/A]

To Whom It May Concern,

I am writing to dispute information appearing on my consumer report that does not belong to me. The information listed below has been associated with my consumer file in error and must be removed.

The following information does not belong to me:

[List each piece of information that is not yours — addresses you have never lived at, names not yours, accounts you never opened, employers you never worked for]

I have repeatedly identified this inaccuracy and your continued reporting of it indicates that my consumer file may be mixed or merged with another consumer's file, possibly a relative or someone with a similar name or Social Security number.

I am formally requesting that you:

1. Flag my consumer file as a potential mixed file
2. Conduct a thorough review to ensure no accounts, inquiries, or public records belonging to another consumer are associated with my Social Security number or consumer file
3. Remove all information identified above from my consumer file within 30 days of receipt of this letter
4. Provide written confirmation of the corrections made

Reporting another consumer's information on my file is a clear violation of the Fair Credit Reporting Act. The bureau has no legal basis to attach data belonging to another person to my consumer file.

If I have included an FTC identity theft report number above, I am also invoking my rights under FCRA §605B, which requires you to block the disputed information from appearing in my consumer file within four business days of receipt of an identity theft report.

CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY

Continued failure to correct this matter will result in a formal complaint to the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau and consultation with a consumer rights attorney regarding civil action under FCRA §616 and §617.

My identifying information:

Full Legal Name: [Name]

CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY

Current Address: [Address]

Date of Birth: [DOB]

Last 4 digits of SSN: [XXXX]

Sincerely,

[Your Printed Name]

CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY

Enclosures:

- ☐ Government-issued photo ID
- ☐ Proof of current address
- ☐ FTC identity theft report (if applicable)

9

PHASE 3 · CLEAN IDENTITY

PI METHOD OF VERIFICATION DEMAND

AFTER "VERIFIED"
RESPONSE

USE THIS LETTER WHEN

- The bureau responded "verified" to your Letter 6 dispute
- The wrong information is still showing on your report after their response
- You need to force them to prove exactly how they verified it

"Verified" is not proof. "Verified" means they asked the furnisher and the furnisher said yes. FCRA §611(a)(7) requires them to tell you exactly how they verified, who they contacted, and what documentation they reviewed. If they cannot produce that, they cannot legally keep reporting it.

AFTER YOU SEND IT

Give them 15 days. If they cannot document their verification process, that is your escalation evidence. Go to Phase 6 with this letter and their original "verified" response attached. Failure to disclose method of verification on demand is a documented FCRA §611(a)(7) violation.

Bureau responded "verified" to Letter 6

↓

SEND LETTER 9 demanding method of verification

↓

Wait 15 days

↓

They produce real verification documentation → Review for inaccuracies

They cannot produce → Demand deletion. Escalate to Phase 6.

No response → Phase 6 (CFPB complaint)

[Your Full Legal Name]

[Your Current Address]

[City, State, ZIP Code]

Date: [Insert Date]

Via Certified Mail · Return Receipt Requested

[Credit Bureau Name]

[Credit Bureau Address]

[City, State, ZIP Code]

Re: Demand for Method of Verification — Personal Information Dispute

Report Number: [Insert if available]

To Whom It May Concern,

On [date of Letter 6], I submitted a formal dispute regarding inaccurate personal information appearing on my consumer report. Specifically, I disputed the following:

[List each item exactly as in Letter 6 — for example: "Address listed as 123 Old Street, Anytown, USA. I have never resided at this address."]

On [date of their response], you responded stating this information was "verified." You did not provide any explanation of how this verification was conducted, who was contacted, or what documentation was reviewed.

Under the Fair Credit Reporting Act §611(a)(7), I am formally requesting the following:

1. A complete description of the procedure used to verify the disputed personal information
2. The name, address, and telephone number of any furnisher or third party contacted during your verification
3. The specific documentation reviewed that led to your determination that this information is accurate

A generic "verified" response does not satisfy your obligations under federal law. If you cannot produce documentation of your verification process, you do not have a legal basis to continue reporting this information on my consumer file.

You have 15 days from receipt of this letter to provide the requested information or remove the disputed items from my report. Failure to do so will result in a formal complaint filed with the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau and pursuit of all remedies under FCRA §616 and §617.

CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY

My identifying information:

Last 4 digits of SSN: [XXXX]

Sincerely,

[Your Printed Name]

CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY

Enclosures:

- ☐ Copy of original Letter 6 dispute
- ☐ Copy of bureau "verified" response

CREDIT ACADEMY

Letter 9 · PI Method of Verification Demand

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PHASE 3 · CLEAN IDENTITY · URGENT

SSN OR DATE OF BIRTH ERRORHIGHEST PRIORITY
IN THE KIT**USE THIS LETTER WHEN**

- Your Social Security number is listed incorrectly on any bureau report
- Your date of birth is wrong on any bureau report
- This is the highest priority PI error in the entire kit. Fix this before sending any other letter.

THE ONLY LETTER WHERE YOU SEND A COPY OF YOUR SOCIAL SECURITY CARD

Do not send SSN documentation to anyone else in this kit. Not collectors. Not creditors. Not other bureau letters. Bureau only. For this letter only. The risk of sending full SSN documentation any other time outweighs the benefit. Here, it is required.

Why this is urgent. An unresolved SSN or DOB error will cause every Phase 4 dispute to fail identity verification and get rejected. The bureau will reject your dispute as "frivolous" or "unable to verify identity," and you will lose dispute time. This must be fixed before anything else.

AFTER YOU SEND IT

Do not wait the full 30 days on this one. Follow up in 20 days. Get the correction confirmed in writing before you move forward with anything else in the kit. Pull a fresh report after correction to verify the change before starting Phase 4.

```
SSN or DOB error identified
↓
Pause everything else
↓
SEND LETTER 10 to each affected bureau separately
↓
Follow up at day 20 if no response
↓
Get written confirmation of correction
↓
Verify on a fresh report
```



THEN proceed with rest of kit

[Your Full Legal Name]

[Your Current Address]

[City, State, ZIP Code]

Date: [Insert Date]

Via Certified Mail · Return Receipt Requested

[Credit Bureau Name]

[Credit Bureau Address]

[City, State, ZIP Code]

Re: URGENT — Social Security Number / Date of Birth Error on Consumer Report

Report Number: [Insert if available]

To Whom It May Concern,

I am writing to formally dispute a critical error in the personal information section of my consumer report.

The following information is currently listed incorrectly. Check all that apply:

☐ **Social Security Number Error**

Currently listed as [wrong number]. My correct SSN ends in [XXXX]. The complete correct number is verified on the Social Security card I have enclosed.

☐ **Date of Birth Error**

Currently listed as [wrong date]. My correct date of birth is [correct date].

This is not a minor discrepancy. An inaccurate Social Security number or date of birth on my consumer report:

- ☐ Directly causes me to fail identity verification with creditors and financial institutions
- ☐ Impairs my ability to exercise my rights as a consumer under federal law
- ☐ May indicate that my file has been mixed with another consumer's file
- ☐ Will cause valid disputes I file in the future to be improperly rejected

Under FCRA §611, I am requesting an immediate investigation and correction of this error. I have enclosed the following documentation to confirm my identity:

- ☐ Copy of government-issued photo ID
- ☐ Copy of my Social Security card
- ☐ Copy of a recent utility bill or bank statement confirming my current address

Please correct this information immediately and send written confirmation that the correction has been made. I am also requesting that you notify any party who received my report in the past 6 months of this correction, as required under FCRA §611(c).

This matter requires urgent attention. I expect a written response within 20 days of receipt of this letter, not the standard 30 days.

Sincerely,

[Your Printed Name]

Enclosures:

- ☐ Government-issued photo ID
- ☐ Social Security card copy
- ☐ Proof of current address

CREDIT ACADEMY

Letter 10 • SSN / DOB Correction • URGENT

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PHASE FOUR

DISPUTE BUREAUS

Rounds 1 and 2. Where most accounts move.

This is the heart of the kit. Phase 4 is where most accounts get deleted, corrected, or set up for the harder push in Phase 5. Round 1 challenges the data. Round 2 challenges the investigation itself when they come back saying "verified." Letters 13 and 14 handle the cases where the bureau ignores you or tries to stall.

TWO RULES THAT PROTECT EVERY DISPUTE YOU SEND

RULE 1 • MAXIMUM 5 ACCOUNTS PER DISPUTE LETTER.

Disputing more than 5 accounts at once signals to the bureau that you are using a credit repair service, which gives them legal grounds to dismiss your disputes as "frivolous." Pick your strongest 5 first. Cycle through additional accounts in later batches.

RULE 2 • MAIL ONLY. NEVER ONLINE.

Online disputes through the bureau portals waive your right to sue under the FCRA. They also limit your legal options if the bureau violates your rights. Certified mail with return receipt only. Always.

01 THE 4 LETTERS IN THIS PHASE

11

ROUND 1 • LETTER 11

Bureau Accuracy Dispute

Your opening move. Dispute specific data points on each account: balance, status, dates, DOFD, payment history, ownership. One letter to each of the three bureaus.

12

ROUND 2 • LETTER 12

Procedure Exposure • MOV Demand

When the bureau responds "verified," you demand the method of verification. They must produce documentation of how they verified, who they contacted, and what records they reviewed.

13**NO-RESPONSE TRACK · LETTER 13****Notice of Intent to File Complaint**

When the bureau ignores you. Formal warning shot before regulatory escalation. Some bureaus delete at this stage to avoid the complaint.

14**FINAL BUREAU LETTER · LETTER 14****Final Violation Notice**

Last formal demand before Phase 6. References the entire paper trail. Cites every specific FCRA violation with dates and tracking numbers.

MOST ACCOUNTS MOVE IN PHASE 4

Round 1 alone moves a meaningful share of disputable accounts. Round 2 moves more. The accounts that survive both rounds go to Phase 5 where the strategy gets sharper. Do not get discouraged when Round 1 comes back with "verified." That is the predictable response, and it is exactly what Round 2 is designed for.

11

PHASE 4 · ROUND 1

BUREAU ACCURACY DISPUTEYOUR ROUND 1
OPENING MOVE**USE THIS LETTER WHEN**

- Your personal information is clean and confirmed correct on all three bureaus
- You are ready to begin disputing negative accounts for the first time
- You have identified specific inaccurate, unverifiable, or erroneous accounts

MAXIMUM 5 ACCOUNTS PER LETTER

Disputing more than 5 accounts at once gives the bureau grounds to dismiss your disputes as frivolous under FCRA §611(a)(3). Pick your 5 strongest. The ones with the clearest factual errors. The ones with the most specific dispute angles. Cycle additional accounts in later rounds.

CERTIFIED MAIL ONLY · NEVER ONLINE

Online disputes waive your right to sue under the FCRA. They also limit your legal options if the bureau violates your rights. Use certified mail with return receipt requested. The certified mail tracking number is your timestamp, your evidence, and your proof of delivery.

AFTER YOU SEND IT

Wait 30 days from the delivery date on each return receipt. Pull your updated reports. Document every response — deletion, correction, "verified," or no response — for each account. Do not send Round 2 until you have their response or 30 days have passed.

Phase 3 PI cleanup confirmed complete

↓

Pick 5 strongest dispute accounts

↓

SEND LETTER 11 to Equifax, Experian, and TransUnion separately

↓

Wait 30 days from delivery

↓

Pull updated reports and document each response

↓

Deleted → Done. Monitor.

Corrected → Document. Monitor.

"Verified" → Letter 12 (Round 2)

No response → Letter 13 (Notice of Intent)

[Your Full Legal Name]

[Your Current Address]

[City, State, ZIP Code]

Date: [Insert Date]

Via Certified Mail · Return Receipt Requested

[Credit Bureau Name]

[Credit Bureau Address]

[City, State, ZIP Code]

Re: Formal Notice of Dispute — Inaccurate Information on Consumer Report

To Whom It May Concern,

I am exercising my right to dispute inaccurate information on my consumer report under the Fair Credit Reporting Act, 15 U.S.C. §1681i. I am requesting that you investigate the following accounts and provide written results of your investigation within 30 days of receipt of this letter.

The following accounts contain inaccurate, incomplete, or unverifiable information. Maximum five accounts per dispute.

Account 1

Creditor Name: [Name]

Account Number: [Number]

Reason for Dispute: [State specifically what is wrong — wrong balance, wrong status, not mine, wrong DOFD, duplicate, etc.]

Action Requested: Delete or correct this account immediately

Account 2

Creditor Name: [Name]

Account Number: [Number]

Reason for Dispute: [Specific reason]

Action Requested: Delete or correct this account immediately

Account 3

Creditor Name: [Name]
Account Number: [Number]
Reason for Dispute: [Specific reason]
Action Requested: Delete or correct this account immediately

Continue for up to 5 accounts total.

Under FCRA §611(a)(1)(A), you are required to conduct a reasonable investigation of each disputed item and provide me with written results within 30 days of receiving this dispute. Under FCRA §611(a)(5)(A), you must delete any item that cannot be verified.

I am also requesting under FCRA §611(a)(7) that you provide the method of verification used for each item investigated, including the name and contact information of any furnisher contacted.

Please send your written response and updated report to my address above.

My identifying information:

Full Legal Name: [Name]
Current Address: [Address]
Date of Birth: [DOB]
Last 4 digits of SSN: [XXXX]

Sincerely,

[Your Printed Name]

Enclosures:

- ☐ Copy of government-issued photo ID
- ☐ Copy of recent utility bill or bank statement

12

PHASE 4 · ROUND 2

PROCEDURE EXPOSURE · MOV DEMAND

AFTER "VERIFIED"
RESPONSE FROM R1

USE THIS LETTER WHEN

- The bureau responded "verified" to your Letter 11 dispute
- The account is still showing on your report with no change
- You are demanding they prove exactly how they verified it

"Verified" is not the end. It is the beginning of Round 2. When a bureau says verified, they are claiming they contacted the furnisher and the furnisher confirmed the information. This letter forces them to show you exactly what that process looked like. Most of the time they cannot produce it because the verification was an automated e-OSCAR ping, not a real investigation.

ATTACH EVIDENCE

Attach a copy of the bureau's "verified" response from Round 1 to this letter before mailing. The letter references their prior response, so the bureau needs to see it cited specifically.

AFTER YOU SEND IT

Give them 15 days. If they cannot produce their verification method, they have no legal basis to keep reporting the account. Demand deletion. If they still verify with no documentation, move to Phase 5 (Letter 15A or 15B — direct furnisher dispute). If they delete, you are done on that account.

Bureau "verified" response received from Letter 11

↓

SEND LETTER 12 with their "verified" response attached

↓

Wait 15 days

↓

Deleted → Done. Monitor.

Real method of verification documented → Review for inaccuracies

Cannot produce method → Demand deletion. Then Phase 5.

Still "verified" with no documentation → Phase 5

[Your Full Legal Name]

[Your Current Address]

[City, State, ZIP Code]

Date: [Insert Date]

Via Certified Mail · Return Receipt Requested

[Credit Bureau Name]

[Credit Bureau Address]

[City, State, ZIP Code]

Re: Second Notice — Failure to Conduct Reasonable Investigation

Original Dispute Date: [Date of Letter 11]

Certified Mail Tracking Number: [Insert]

To Whom It May Concern,

You previously responded stating the disputed account(s) below were "verified." You did not provide documentation or a sufficient description of your investigation process.

Disputed Account(s)

[List each account by Creditor Name and Account Number]

Under FCRA §611(a)(7), I am formally requesting:

1. A complete description of the procedure used to verify each disputed account
2. The name and contact information of the party relied upon during verification
3. The documentation reviewed to confirm the accuracy of each disputed data point

A generic or automated verification does not meet the standard of a reasonable investigation. The use of e-OSCAR alone, without supporting documentation review, does not satisfy your obligations under FCRA §611(a)(1)(A).

Specifically, for each account listed above, I am requiring verification of:

- ☐ Date of first delinquency as it appears in their records
- ☐ Full payment history from account opening to present
- ☐ Current balance and the method used to calculate it
- ☐ Account status and reporting consistency across all three bureaus
- ☐ Documentation of the furnisher's legal authority to report or collect

CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY

If you are unable to provide this documentation within 15 days of receipt of this letter, the continued reporting of these accounts constitutes inaccurate and incomplete reporting in violation of federal law, and the disputed items must be deleted under FCRA §611(a)(5)(A).

This correspondence serves as documentation of your investigation process and compliance.

CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY

My identifying information:

Last 4 digits of SSN: [XXXX]

Sincerely,

[Your Printed Name]

CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY

Enclosure:

☐ Copy of bureau "verified" response dated [date]

CREDIT ACADEMY

Letter 12 · Round 2 Procedure Exposure

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13

PHASE 4 · NO-RESPONSE TRACK

NOTICE OF INTENT TO FILE COMPLAINT

WHEN BUREAU
IGNORES YOU

USE THIS LETTER WHEN

- The bureau has not responded to Letter 11 after 30 days, or has not responded to Letter 12 after 15 days
- You have delivery confirmation proving they received your prior letter
- You are putting them on formal notice before escalating to Phase 6

This is a warning shot, not a dispute letter. You are telling them exactly what you are about to do and giving them one final opportunity to resolve it before you escalate. Some bureaus delete at this stage to avoid the formal complaint. Send it and mean it.

AFTER YOU SEND IT

Give them 10 days only. This window is shorter because they have already had their full investigation time. If they do not respond or delete, go directly to Phase 6 and file your CFPB complaint. Bring every letter and every delivery receipt with you.

No response from bureau after 30 days of Letter 11 or 15 days of Letter 12

↓

SEND LETTER 13 with all prior letters and delivery receipts attached

↓

Wait 10 days only

↓

Deletion or correction → Done. Monitor.

No response → Phase 6 immediately

[Your Full Legal Name]

[Your Current Address]

[City, State, ZIP Code]

Date: [Insert Date]

Via Certified Mail · Return Receipt Requested

[Credit Bureau Name]

[Credit Bureau Address]

[City, State, ZIP Code]

Re: Notice of Intent to File Federal Complaint — Failure to Investigate Consumer Dispute

Original Dispute Date: [Date]

Certified Mail Tracking Number: [Insert]

To Whom It May Concern,

This letter serves as formal notice that I intend to file a complaint with the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau and pursue all available legal remedies under the Fair Credit Reporting Act if the matters outlined below are not resolved within 10 days of receipt of this letter.

On [date of original dispute], I submitted a formal written dispute regarding the accounts listed below. On [date of follow-up if applicable], I submitted a follow-up demand. You received both letters as confirmed by my certified mail records, copies of which are enclosed.

To date you have failed to:

- ☐ Conduct a reasonable investigation as required by FCRA §611(a)(1)(A)
- ☐ Provide written results of your investigation within the legally required timeframe
- ☐ Delete or correct items that could not be verified
- ☐ Provide the method of verification as required by FCRA §611(a)(7)

The accounts in question are:

[List each account by Creditor Name and Account Number]

Your failure to comply with these federal requirements constitutes a violation of the Fair Credit Reporting Act. Under FCRA §616 and §617, I am entitled to pursue actual damages, statutory damages of up to \$1,000 per violation, punitive damages, and attorney fees.

I am giving you 10 days from receipt of this letter to delete the accounts listed above or provide full written documentation of your verification process. If I do not receive a satisfactory response within that

CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY

timeframe, I will proceed without further notice with:

1. A formal complaint with the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau
2. A complaint with the Federal Trade Commission
3. A complaint with my state Attorney General
4. Consultation with a consumer rights attorney regarding civil action

CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY

I am preserving all correspondence, certified mail receipts, and documentation related to this matter.

My identifying information:

Last 4 digits of SSN: [XXXX]

Sincerely,

CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY

[Your Printed Name]

Enclosures:

- ☐ All prior dispute letters
- ☐ All certified mail delivery confirmations

CREDIT ACADEMY

Letter 13 · Notice of Intent to File Complaint

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14

PHASE 4 · FINAL BUREAU LETTER

FINAL VIOLATION NOTICELAST BUREAU LETTER
BEFORE PHASE 6**USE THIS LETTER WHEN**

- You have sent Letters 11, 12, and 13, and the account is still on your report
- You have documented evidence of the bureau's failure to investigate or respond
- You are making a final formal demand before legal and regulatory action

SEND ONLY WITH DOCUMENTATION ORGANIZED

Every prior letter you sent, every delivery receipt, every response they gave you is now evidence. This letter references all of it. Do not send Letter 14 unless you have that documentation organized and ready. Make copies and keep originals.

AFTER YOU SEND IT

Do not wait more than 10 days. If no resolution, go directly to Phase 6. You now have a fully documented paper trail of FCRA violations. That documentation is valuable whether you file a CFPB complaint, contact an attorney, or both.

[Your Full Legal Name]

[Your Current Address]

[City, State, ZIP Code]

Date: [Insert Date]

Via Certified Mail · Return Receipt Requested

[Credit Bureau Name]

[Credit Bureau Address]

[City, State, ZIP Code]

Re: Final Notice of FCRA Violations — Demand for Immediate Deletion

Original Dispute Date: [Date of Letter 11]

Certified Mail Tracking Number: [Insert]

To Whom It May Concern,

This is my final written communication to you regarding the accounts listed below before I pursue all available legal and regulatory remedies.

I have submitted the following correspondence regarding these accounts, all sent via certified mail with confirmed delivery:

- ☐ Letter 11 — Initial Accuracy Dispute · Sent [date] · Received [date]
- ☐ Letter 12 — Procedure Exposure / MOV Demand · Sent [date] · Received [date]
- ☐ Letter 13 — Notice of Intent · Sent [date] · Received [date]

You have committed the following specific FCRA violations. Check all that apply.

- ☐ FCRA §611(a)(1)(A) — Failure to conduct a reasonable investigation within 30 days
- ☐ FCRA §611(a)(5)(A) — Failure to delete items that could not be properly verified
- ☐ FCRA §611(a)(7) — Failure to provide the method of verification upon request
- ☐ FCRA §623(b) — Failure to properly investigate a direct consumer dispute

The accounts in question are:

Account 1 · Creditor Name: [Name] · Account Number: [Number] · Violation: [Describe specifically]

Account 2 · Creditor Name: [Name] · Account Number: [Number] · Violation: [Describe specifically]

I am demanding immediate deletion of all accounts listed above from my consumer file. These accounts have not been properly verified and your continued reporting of them constitutes ongoing violations of federal law.

CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY

If these accounts are not deleted and written confirmation provided to me within 10 days of receipt of this letter, I will immediately pursue without further notice:

1. Formal CFPB complaint with full documentation
2. FTC complaint
3. State Attorney General complaint
4. Consultation with a consumer rights attorney regarding civil action under FCRA §616 and §617

CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY

Under those statutes I am entitled to actual damages, statutory damages up to \$1,000 per violation, punitive damages, and attorney fees. I have retained all documentation and am prepared to proceed.

My identifying information:

Last 4 digits of SSN: [XXXX]

Sincerely,

CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY

[Your Printed Name]

Enclosures:

- ☐ Copies of all prior correspondence (Letters 11, 12, 13)
- ☐ All certified mail delivery confirmations
- ☐ Copy of consumer report showing the disputed accounts

PHASE FIVE

CHALLENGE FURNISHERS

Rounds 3, 4, and 5. Where the stubborn accounts crack.

This phase changes the angle. Up until now, you have been talking to the bureaus. In Phase 5, you go directly to the source — the company actually furnishing the data. Collectors get FCRA and FDCPA. Original creditors get FCRA only. Most accounts that survive Phase 4 break here, because the furnisher cannot quietly verify to the bureau when your direct dispute is sitting on their desk at the same time.

01 THE LETTERS IN THIS PHASE

15A**ROUND 4 • LETTER 15A****Direct Furnisher Dispute • Collection Agency**

Sent directly to the collector. FCRA §623(a)(8) gives you the right to dispute directly with the furnisher. Sent same day as Letter 15C.

15B**ROUND 4 • LETTER 15B****Direct Furnisher Dispute • Original Creditor**

Sent directly to the original creditor on charge-offs they still own. FCRA only, no FDCPA. Sent same day as Letter 15C.

15C**ROUND 5 • LETTER 15C****Bureau Companion • Concurrent Investigation**

Sent to each bureau on the same day as 15A or 15B. Forces concurrent investigations. Both sides cannot quietly defer to each other.

16

ROUND 3 ALTERNATIVE · LETTER 16

Inconsistency Attack

When the same account reports differently across bureaus. The contradiction itself is the dispute. You do not need to know which bureau is right.

17

ADVANCED · LETTER 17

Charge-Off Violation Dispute

Stacked attack on a charge-off. DOFD errors, balance inflation, dual-status reporting, duplicate reporting. Each violation is a separate FCRA claim.

18

NEGOTIATION · LETTER 18

Pay for Delete

Optional. Used when the debt is valid and you are willing to pay in exchange for deletion. Always get the agreement in writing before paying.

19

INQUIRY REMOVAL · LETTER 19

Unauthorized Hard Inquiry Removal

Goes directly to the creditor who pulled your credit without permissible purpose under FCRA §604.

15A

PHASE 5 · ROUND 4

DIRECT FURNISHER DISPUTE · COLLECTION AGENCYSEND SAME DAY
AS LETTER 15C**USE THIS LETTER WHEN**

- The account is a collection currently being reported by a collection agency
- Phase 4 (Letters 11–14) is complete and the account is still on your report
- You are ready to bypass the bureau and dispute directly with the furnisher

LETTERS 15A AND 15C ARE A PAIR

Mail both letters the same morning. Letter 15A goes to the collector. Letter 15C goes to each bureau showing the account. Sending both simultaneously forces the furnisher and the bureau to investigate at the same time. Neither can defer to the other.

AFTER YOU SEND IT

Wait 30 days. Document every response from both the collector and each bureau. If unresolved, identify which advanced letter applies. If consistent across bureaus but still on report, go to Letter 17 for advanced charge-off violations or Letter 18 for negotiation. If still no resolution, go to Phase 6.

Phase 4 complete, account still reporting

↓

SEND LETTER 15A to collector disputes department

SEND LETTER 15C to each bureau · same day

↓

Wait 30 days

↓

Deleted → Done. Monitor.

Corrected → Document. Monitor.

Inconsistent across bureaus → Letter 16

Specific charge-off violations identified → Letter 17

Willing to pay for deletion → Letter 18

No response or still verified → Phase 6

PHASE 5 · ROUND 4 **LETTER 15A — DIRECT FURNISHER DISPUTE · COLLECTION AGENCY**

[Your Full Legal Name]

[Your Current Address]

[City, State, ZIP Code]

Date: [Insert Date]

Via Certified Mail · Return Receipt Requested

[Collection Agency Name]

[Disputes Department Address]

[City, State, ZIP Code]

Re: Direct Dispute of Inaccurate Information Being Reported to Consumer Reporting Agencies

Account Number: [Insert Account Number]

To Whom It May Concern,

Pursuant to my rights under the Fair Credit Reporting Act 15 U.S.C. §1681s-2(a)(8), I am submitting this direct dispute regarding inaccurate and/or unverifiable information you are currently furnishing to one or more consumer reporting agencies in connection with the above-referenced account.

You are required under FCRA §623(a)(8) to conduct an investigation of this dispute, review all relevant information I am providing, and correct or delete any information you cannot verify.

I am requesting verification of the following specific data points:

- ☐ Date of first delinquency as it appears in your records
- ☐ Full payment history from account opening to present
- ☐ Current balance and the method used to calculate it
- ☐ Account status and reporting consistency across all three bureaus
- ☐ Documentation of your legal authority to collect or report this debt — a specific assignment, not a bulk purchase agreement
- ☐ Name and address of the original creditor if different from your organization

Please provide the method of verification used for each item, including the name of any party contacted and the procedure followed. A cursory or automated response does not satisfy your obligations under federal law.

I am requesting that you:

1. Conduct a full investigation of all data points listed above
2. Correct or delete any information that cannot be fully verified
3. Notify all consumer reporting agencies of any correction or deletion

4. Provide written confirmation of your investigation results within 30 days

Please be advised that I am simultaneously submitting a dispute to the consumer reporting agencies regarding this account. Both investigations will be running concurrently.

Under FCRA §623(a)(8)(E), you are required to complete your investigation and report results to the consumer reporting agency within the same timeframe required of the bureau. Failure to investigate or correct inaccurate information constitutes a violation of FCRA §1681s-2(a). Failure to verify accuracy requires deletion.

My identifying information:

Full Legal Name: [Name]

Last 4 digits of SSN: [XXXX]

Sincerely,

[Your Printed Name]

Enclosures:

- ☐ Copy of consumer report showing the disputed information
- ☐ Any supporting documentation of the inaccuracy

15B

PHASE 5 · ROUND 4

DIRECT FURNISHER DISPUTE · ORIGINAL CREDITORSEND SAME DAY
AS LETTER 15C**USE THIS LETTER WHEN**

- The account is a charge-off that the original creditor (OC) is still reporting directly
- The account has not been sold to a collection agency, OR both OC and collector are reporting
- Phase 4 is complete and the account is still on your report

The legal difference from 15A. The original creditor is not a debt collector under FDCPA, so the FDCPA validation framework does not apply. They are still a furnisher under FCRA, so §623(a)(8) and §623(b)(1) apply. This letter uses FCRA only.

LETTERS 15B AND 15C ARE A PAIR

Mail 15B to the original creditor's disputes department and 15C to each bureau on the same day. The simultaneous pressure is the strategy.

AFTER YOU SEND IT

Wait 30 days. Document responses from the original creditor and each bureau separately. If verified again with no documentation, escalate per the Letter 15A decision flow. If specific charge-off violations are present, Letter 17 stacks the case.

[Your Full Legal Name]

[Your Current Address]

[City, State, ZIP Code]

Date: [Insert Date]

Via Certified Mail · Return Receipt Requested

[Original Creditor Name]

[Disputes Department Address]

[City, State, ZIP Code]

Re: Direct Dispute of Inaccurate Information Being Furnished to Consumer Reporting Agencies

Account Number: [Insert Account Number]

To Whom It May Concern,

I am submitting this direct dispute regarding inaccurate and/or unverifiable information your organization is furnishing to one or more consumer reporting agencies on the above-referenced account, pursuant to FCRA §623(a)(8).

You have an independent legal obligation under FCRA §623(b)(1) to investigate this dispute, review all relevant records, and correct or delete information that cannot be verified. You may not rely on the consumer reporting agency's prior verifications as your response.

I am specifically disputing the accuracy of the following data points being furnished:

- ☐ Date of first delinquency
- ☐ Full payment history from account opening
- ☐ Current balance and balance progression after charge-off, if applicable
- ☐ Account status and reporting consistency across all three bureaus
- ☐ Any indication of duplicate reporting if the debt was sold or transferred

Under FCRA §623(b)(1), you are required to:

1. Conduct an independent investigation of the disputed information
2. Review all relevant records in your possession
3. Correct or delete any information you cannot verify
4. Notify the credit reporting bureaus of any changes

If you are unable to verify the accuracy of each disputed data point with documentation, you are required to instruct all credit reporting bureaus to delete or correct this account accordingly.

CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY

I am simultaneously submitting a concurrent dispute to all three consumer reporting agencies. Both investigations will be running at the same time. Failure to investigate or correct inaccurate information constitutes a violation of FCRA §1681s-2(a).

My identifying information:

CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY

Last 4 digits of SSN: [XXXX]

Sincerely,

[Your Printed Name]

CREDIT ACADEMY

Letter 15B · Direct Furnisher Dispute · Original Creditor

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15C

PHASE 5 · ROUND 5

BUREAU COMPANION · CONCURRENT INVESTIGATIONMAIL SAME DAY
AS 15A OR 15B**USE THIS LETTER WHEN**

- You are sending Letter 15A or 15B today
- You need to notify each bureau of the simultaneous direct furnisher dispute
- You are forcing concurrent investigations

This letter is the second half of a pair. The collector or original creditor receives 15A or 15B. Each of the three bureaus receives 15C. They all go in the mail the same morning. The bureaus are now legally on notice that an active direct furnisher dispute exists. Both sides must investigate independently. Neither side can quietly defer to the other.

AFTER YOU SEND IT

Wait 30 days from each delivery date. Document responses from each bureau separately and from the furnisher. Compare what each side says. Inconsistent responses across the four parties (one furnisher and three bureaus) become Letter 16 ammunition. Consistent verification with no real documentation becomes Phase 6 ammunition.

[Your Full Legal Name]

[Your Current Address]

[City, State, ZIP Code]

Date: [Insert Date]

Via Certified Mail · Return Receipt Requested

[Credit Bureau Name]

[Credit Bureau Address]

[City, State, ZIP Code]

Re: Notice of Direct Furnisher Dispute — Concurrent Investigation Request
Account Number: [Insert Account Number]

To Whom It May Concern,

I am writing to notify you that I have submitted a direct dispute to [Furnisher Name] today, [insert date], regarding inaccurate and/or unverifiable information they are furnishing to your agency in connection with the above-referenced account. A copy of that direct dispute is enclosed.

This letter serves as formal notice of that direct dispute and a concurrent request that your agency also investigate the accuracy of the information being reported on this account.

The account currently appears on my consumer report as follows:

Account Name: [Creditor Name]

Account Number: [Number]

Current Reported Status: [What your report shows]

Current Reported Balance: [What your report shows]

Under FCRA §611(a)(1)(A), I am requesting that you conduct your own independent investigation of this account simultaneously with the furnisher's investigation. You have an independent obligation to reinvestigate. You may not simply defer to the furnisher's response.

Under FCRA §611(a)(5)(A), any information that cannot be verified must be deleted from my consumer file.

I have documentation of all prior disputes regarding this account and am retaining all correspondence for regulatory and legal purposes.

I am specifically also invoking my right under FCRA §611(a)(7) and requesting that this dispute be assigned to a human reviewer, not processed solely through an automated system. An e-OSCAR code exchange

CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY

does not constitute a reasonable investigation when specific data accuracy is in dispute.

My identifying information:

Full Legal Name: [Name]

Last 4 digits of SSN: [XXXX]

CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY

Sincerely,

[Your Printed Name]

Enclosures:

- ☐ Copy of consumer report showing the disputed account
- ☐ Copy of direct dispute letter sent to furnisher today

CREDIT ACADEMY

Letter 15C · Bureau Companion · Concurrent Investigation

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16

PHASE 5 · ROUND 3 ALTERNATIVE

INCONSISTENCY ATTACKCROSS-BUREAU
CONTRADICTIONS**USE THIS LETTER WHEN**

- The same account is reporting differently across two or more bureaus
- Balance, status, dates, or any data point shows inconsistent information
- You have already disputed at the bureau level and gotten "verified" responses

The contradiction itself is your dispute. You do not need to know which bureau is right and which is wrong. If three bureaus are reporting three different balances, two of them have to be wrong by definition. Inconsistent reporting across bureaus is direct evidence of inaccuracy under FCRA §1681s-2(a).

AFTER YOU SEND IT

Send to the furnisher and to all three bureaus. Wait 30 days. The bureaus and the furnisher must reconcile, which often results in deletion because verifying through e-OSCAR cannot resolve which version of the data is correct.

[Your Full Legal Name]

[Your Current Address]

[City, State, ZIP Code]

Date: [Insert Date]

Via Certified Mail · Return Receipt Requested

[Furnisher or Bureau Name]

[Address]

[City, State, ZIP Code]

Re: Notice of Inconsistent and Unreliable Reporting

Account Number: [Insert Account Number]

To Whom It May Concern,

I am writing regarding the following account, which has been reported as "verified as accurate" but contains inconsistencies across consumer reporting agencies that establish material inaccuracy on the face of the data.

Account Name: [Creditor Name] · Account Number: [XXXX]

The information being reported is inconsistent across the three bureaus as follows:

Equifax reports: [balance, status, DOFD, etc.]

Experian reports: [balance, status, DOFD, etc.]

TransUnion reports: [balance, status, DOFD, etc.]

Specifically, the inconsistencies include:

- ☐ Different balances on each bureau report
- ☐ Different account statuses across bureaus
- ☐ Different dates of first delinquency or last activity
- ☐ Different payment history records

Under the Fair Credit Reporting Act, all information reported must be both accurate and complete. Information that is inconsistent across sources cannot, by definition, all be accurate. The inconsistencies present raise serious concerns regarding the accuracy and integrity of this reporting.

If this account has been verified as accurate, then the information should be consistent, reliable, and supported by the same underlying records across all furnishers and bureaus. The inconsistencies I have documented prove this verification is not reliable.

CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY

I am requesting that you conduct a reinvestigation and either:

1. Correct the inconsistent information to reflect a complete and accurate single record
2. Remove the account if it cannot be verified with consistency and reliability across all reporting

I expect a response reflecting a proper investigation within the time allowed by law. The continued furnishing of inconsistent data across multiple consumer reporting agencies after this notice constitutes a knowing violation of FCRA §1681s-2(a).

CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY

My identifying information:

Last 4 digits of SSN: [XXXX]

Sincerely,

[Your Printed Name]

CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY

Enclosure:

- ☐ Copies of all three bureau reports highlighting the inconsistencies

17

PHASE 5 · ADVANCED

CHARGE-OFF VIOLATION DISPUTESTACK EACH VIOLATION
THAT APPLIES**USE THIS LETTER WHEN**

- The account is a charge-off specifically
- Letters 15A or 15B and 15C have been sent and the account was verified again
- You have identified one or more specific charge-off violations
- Check all four violation types and mark which apply

CHECK THESE 4 VIOLATIONS BEFORE WRITING THIS LETTER**1 · DOFD ERROR.**

Wrong date keeps account on report past 7-year legal limit.

2 · BALANCE INFLATION.

Balance increasing after charge-off date with no legal basis.

3 · DUAL-STATUS REPORTING.

Different status showing on different bureaus simultaneously.

4 · DUAL REPORTING.

Original creditor and collector both reporting the same debt at the same time.

Each violation that applies is a separate FCRA §1681s-2(a) claim. Stack all that apply.

AFTER YOU SEND IT

Give them 15 days. If unresolved, go to Phase 6 immediately. A charge-off with documented violations is one of the strongest cases you can bring to the CFPB or a consumer rights attorney.

Charge-off verified after Letters 15A/B and 15C

↓

Check all 4 violations · document every one that applies

↓

SEND LETTER 17 to furnisher via certified mail

↓

Wait 15 days

↓

Deleted → Done. Monitor.

Corrected → Document and monitor.
No resolution → Phase 6 immediately

[Your Full Legal Name]

[Your Current Address]

[City, State, ZIP Code]

Date: [Insert Date]

Via Certified Mail · Return Receipt Requested

[Creditor or Collection Agency Name]

[Disputes Department Address]

[City, State, ZIP Code]

Re: Dispute of Charged-Off Account — DOFD Inaccuracy, Metro 2 Dual-Status Violation, and Unverifiable Balance

Account Number: [XXXX]

Original Creditor: [If different from current furnisher]

To Whom It May Concern,

I am disputing this charged-off account on the basis of multiple specific inaccuracies in how it is being reported. A charge-off is an accounting action taken by the creditor. It does not validate the accuracy of the data being reported to my consumer file.

I am disputing the following. Check all that apply.

☐ **Date of First Delinquency (DOFD)**

The DOFD you are reporting is [date]. The actual DOFD was [correct date]. Under FCRA §623(a)(5), the furnisher is required to report the accurate DOFD. An inaccurate DOFD directly affects when this account must be removed under FCRA §605(a)(4). This constitutes a reportable violation.

☐ **Metro 2 Dual-Status Violation**

This account is being reported simultaneously as "charged off" and carrying an active past-due balance. Under Metro 2 reporting standards, a charged-off account in status code 97 may not also carry monthly delinquency codes. This is an internal reporting inconsistency and a Metro 2 compliance failure.

☐ **Post-Charge-Off Balance Inflation**

The balance currently reported (\$[amount]) exceeds the balance at the time of charge-off. Increases to a charged-off balance that are not authorized by the original credit agreement are not accurately reportable under the FCRA.

☐ **Duplicate Reporting**

This same debt is also appearing as a collection account under [Collection Agency Name]. A single debt cannot be reported twice as two separate negative accounts.

Under FCRA §611(a)(5)(A), any information that cannot be verified must be deleted. I am requesting verification of each specific item listed above, **not general confirmation that the account exists.**

I am simultaneously notifying all three credit reporting agencies of this direct dispute. Failure to investigate or correct each inaccuracy listed above constitutes a separate violation of FCRA §1681s-2(a).

My identifying information:

Last 4 digits of SSN: [XXXX]

Sincerely,

[Your Printed Name]

18

PHASE 5 · NEGOTIATION

PAY FOR DELETEOPTIONAL · USE ONLY WHEN
WILLING TO PAY VALID DEBT**USE THIS LETTER WHEN**

- The debt is valid and you have the funds available to pay
- You want to negotiate removal rather than just payment
- The collection is recent enough that the collector has motivation to collect

A PAY-FOR-DELETE IS A NEGOTIATION, NOT A RIGHT

The collector is not legally required to agree. Never pay first and ask for deletion after. Get the full agreement in writing on their letterhead before you pay a single dollar. If they will not put it in writing, do not pay. The verbal promise has no enforceability.

STATUTE OF LIMITATIONS WARNING

Do not use this letter on debts past your state's statute of limitations. Paying or even acknowledging a time-barred debt can restart the collection clock and revive a debt that was no longer legally collectable. Check your state's SOL on consumer debt before sending. Most states fall in the 3 to 6 year range, but a few are longer.

AFTER YOU SEND IT

Wait for their written response. If they agree, get the full signed agreement on their letterhead before sending any payment. Pay only by traceable method — money order or cashier's check, never personal check or electronic payment that gives them additional information. After payment clears, send a follow-up demanding compliance per the agreement.

[Your Full Legal Name]

[Your Current Address]

[City, State, ZIP Code]

Date: [Insert Date]

Via Certified Mail · Return Receipt Requested

[Collection Agency or Creditor Name]

[Settlement / Recovery Department Address]

[City, State, ZIP Code]

Re: Settlement Offer — Pay for Delete

Account Number: [Insert Account Number]

Current Reported Balance: [Insert]

To Whom It May Concern,

This letter is a settlement offer regarding the above-referenced account. This is not an admission of liability, an acknowledgment of the debt, or a waiver of any consumer rights. This is a settlement offer made for the limited purpose of resolving the credit reporting impact of this account.

I am offering to pay **\$[settlement amount]** as full and final settlement of this account in exchange for the following written terms:

1. Complete deletion of this account from all three consumer reporting agencies — Equifax, Experian, and TransUnion — within 30 days of receipt of payment
2. Written confirmation that this account has been deleted from all three bureaus, sent to me directly
3. Written agreement that this matter is resolved in full and that no further collection activity will occur
4. Written agreement that this account will not be sold, transferred, or assigned to any other party

This offer is contingent on receiving the above terms in writing on your company letterhead, signed by an authorized representative, before any payment is rendered. Verbal agreements or email confirmations alone are not acceptable.

If you accept these terms, please send the signed agreement to my address listed above. Upon receipt of the signed agreement, I will issue payment by money order or cashier's check within 7 business days.

If these terms are unacceptable, please respond with a counter-offer in writing. If I do not receive a written response within 30 days of receipt of this letter, I will consider this offer withdrawn and will continue with the dispute process under FCRA and FDCPA.

I am retaining this correspondence for my records.

CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY

My identifying information:

Last 4 digits of SSN: [XXXX]

Sincerely,

[Your Printed Name]

CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY

CREDIT ACADEMY

Letter 18 · Pay for Delete Offer

shondamartin.com

19

PHASE 5 · INQUIRY REMOVAL

UNAUTHORIZED HARD INQUIRY REMOVALSEPARATE TRACK FROM
ACCOUNT DISPUTES**USE THIS LETTER WHEN**

- A hard inquiry appears on your report from a creditor you did not authorize to pull your credit
- You did not apply for credit with this creditor
- You did not give written or verbal permission for the pull

FCRA §604 governs permissible purpose. A creditor may only pull your credit when there is a "permissible purpose" under federal law. Most often that means you applied for credit with them. If they cannot show permissible purpose, they violated the FCRA by pulling your credit, and the inquiry must be removed.

SEND THIS DIRECTLY TO THE CREDITOR

Not to the bureau. The creditor pulled the inquiry, so the creditor must request the inquiry's removal. If the creditor refuses, you can then dispute the inquiry with the bureau citing FCRA §604 and your written demand to the creditor as evidence.

AFTER YOU SEND IT

Wait 30 days for the creditor's response. If removed, monitor the bureau reports for the deletion. If the creditor refuses or ignores, file a CFPB complaint citing FCRA §604 violation, and dispute the inquiry directly with each bureau attaching your demand letter and any creditor response as evidence.

[Your Full Legal Name]

[Your Current Address]

[City, State, ZIP Code]

Date: [Insert Date]

Via Certified Mail · Return Receipt Requested

[Creditor Name]

[Compliance or Legal Department Address]

[City, State, ZIP Code]

Re: Demand for Removal of Unauthorized Hard Inquiry — FCRA §604 Permissible Purpose Violation

Date of Inquiry: [Date]

Bureau(s) Where Reported: [List]

To Whom It May Concern,

I have reviewed my consumer credit reports and identified a hard inquiry placed on my file by your organization on [date of inquiry]. I have no record of authorizing this inquiry.

Under the Fair Credit Reporting Act §604, a consumer reporting agency may only furnish a consumer report for a "permissible purpose," and a creditor may only obtain a consumer report when one of those permissible purposes exists. The most common permissible purpose is a written or otherwise documented credit application initiated by the consumer.

I did not initiate any application, request, or transaction with your organization that would create a permissible purpose for pulling my credit. Specifically:

- ☐ I did not apply for credit, financing, or any product offered by your organization
- ☐ I did not give verbal, written, or electronic authorization for a credit pull
- ☐ I do not have an existing account or business relationship with your organization that would authorize an account review

I am formally demanding the following:

1. Documentation showing the permissible purpose under which my credit report was obtained, including any signed application or recorded authorization
2. Removal of this hard inquiry from my consumer report at all three bureaus within 30 days
3. Written confirmation that the inquiry has been removed

If you cannot produce documentation of a permissible purpose, your organization violated FCRA §604 by obtaining my consumer report without authorization. Under FCRA §616, this exposes your organization to actual damages, statutory damages, punitive damages, and attorney fees.

CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY

If this matter is not resolved within 30 days, I will:

1. File a formal complaint with the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau
2. Dispute the inquiry directly with each consumer reporting agency, citing this letter and the FCRA §604 violation as evidence
3. Consult with a consumer rights attorney regarding civil action

CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY

My identifying information:

Full Legal Name: [Name]

Date of Birth: [DOB]

Last 4 digits of SSN: [XXXX]

Sincerely,

CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY · CREDIT ACADEMY

[Your Printed Name]

CREDIT ACADEMY

Letter 19 · Unauthorized Hard Inquiry Removal

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PHASE SIX

ESCALATE

CFPB. FTC. State AG. Attorney consultation.

Most cases never reach this phase, and that is the point. Phase 6 exists for the accounts that survived all five rounds of disputing. By the time you arrive here, you have a documented paper trail of specific federal violations. You are not complaining. You are filing a regulatory complaint backed by evidence, with statutory remedies attached.

01 WHEN YOU ARRIVE HERE

Use Phase 6 only if one or more of these is true:

- ☐ You completed Rounds 1 through 5 and the account is still on your report
- ☐ The bureau ignored you for 30+ days after a properly documented dispute
- ☐ The furnisher refused to investigate or refused to produce method of verification
- ☐ You have documented inconsistencies that the bureau verified anyway
- ☐ You suspect intentional, willful FCRA violation

02 YOUR FOUR ESCALATION PATHS

FIRST

CFPB COMPLAINT

Free. Fast. Forces the bureau or furnisher to respond within 15 days through the federal complaint system. Walk-through on the next pages.

15-DAY RESPONSE • FREE

SECOND

FTC COMPLAINT

For broader patterns of consumer abuse. The FTC does not investigate individual cases the way the CFPB does, but FTC complaints contribute to investigations and create record.

PATTERN RECORD • FREE

THIRD

STATE ATTORNEY GENERAL

State AGs enforce state consumer protection law alongside federal law. State AG complaints often get faster engagement on cases in their jurisdiction.

STATE LAW LEVERAGE · FREE

FOURTH

CONSUMER RIGHTS ATTORNEY

FCRA cases pay attorney fees on the defendant's side under §616 and §617. Many consumer rights attorneys take FCRA cases on contingency. Free consultation.

CIVIL ACTION · OFTEN CONTINGENCY

WHAT PHASE 6 ACTUALLY ACCOMPLISHES

Filing a CFPB complaint does not just document a grievance. It opens a federal complaint file the bureau or furnisher must respond to within 15 days. Many disputes that survived all five rounds resolve at this stage because the regulatory pressure changes the calculus for the bureau or furnisher.

CFPB FILING • STEP BY STEP

HOW TO FILE A CFPB COMPLAINT.

The next pages walk through the consumerfinance.gov complaint form screen by screen. Have your documentation organized before you start. The whole process takes 20 to 30 minutes if you are prepared.

01 BEFORE YOU BEGIN • DOCUMENTATION CHECKLIST

The CFPB complaint asks you to upload supporting documentation. Have these ready:

- ☐ Copies of your dispute letters (Letters 11–17, whichever applied)
- ☐ Certified mail receipts and delivery confirmations for every letter
- ☐ Bureau or furnisher responses you received, dated
- ☐ Copy of your most recent consumer report showing the disputed account
- ☐ Any prior correspondence, settlement offers, or acknowledgments
- ☐ A clear timeline document with dates, tracking numbers, and outcomes

HAVE FILE NAMES ORGANIZED BEFORE UPLOADING

Name your files clearly. "01_Letter11_Round1_dispute_2026-01-15.pdf" reads cleaner than "Scan_001.pdf" both for you and for the CFPB reviewer assigned to your case. Upload up to 25 files. Each file under 25MB.

02 WHAT TO EXPECT AFTER FILING**1****Within 24 hours**

You receive a CFPB complaint number and confirmation email. The CFPB forwards your complaint to the bureau or furnisher.

2**Within 15 days**

The bureau or furnisher must provide an initial response through the CFPB portal. You will be notified.

3**Within 60 days**

Final substantive response from the bureau or furnisher. You can review their response and submit feedback through the CFPB portal.

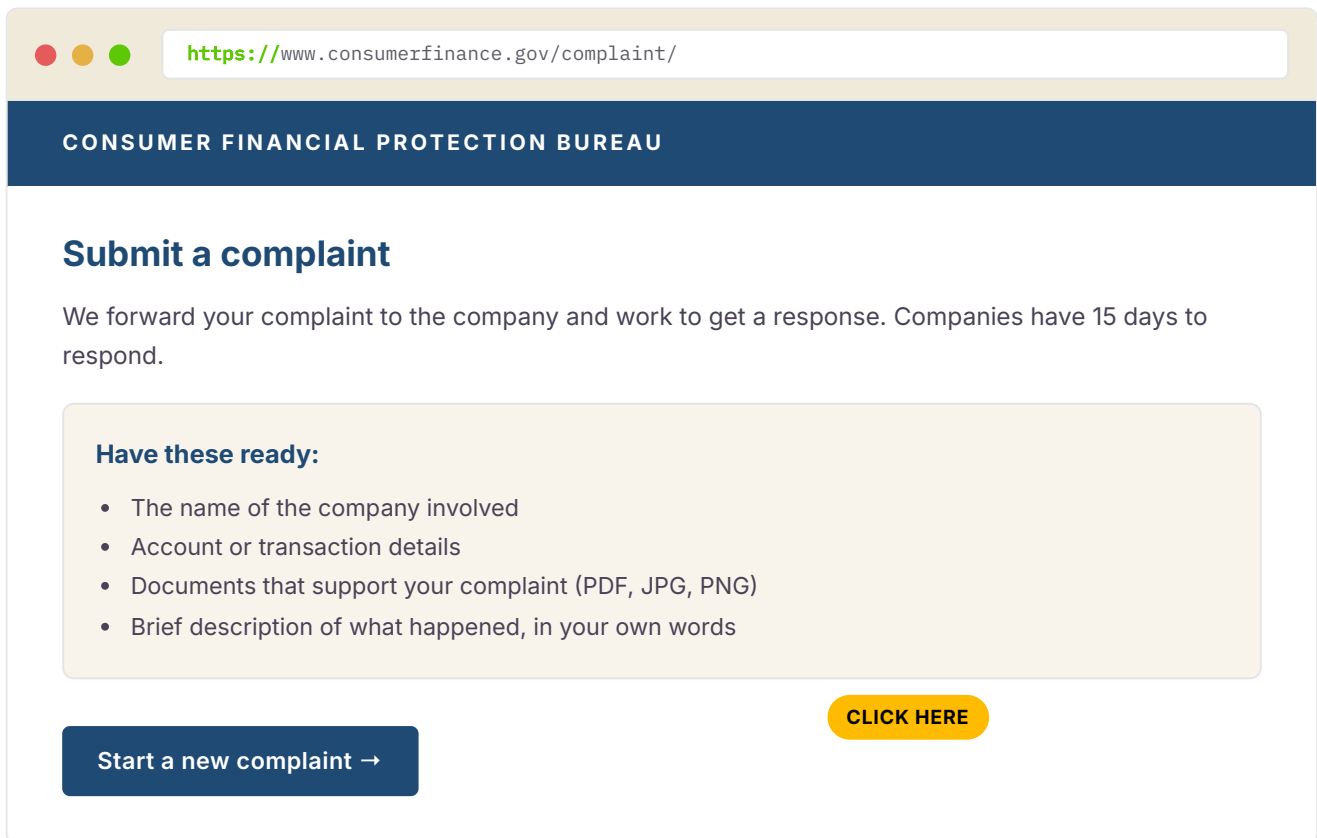
1

CFPB STEP 1

GO TO THE OFFICIAL SITE.

Open your browser and navigate to the CFPB's consumer complaint page.

Bookmark this page now so you can return to it later when you need to check your complaint status.

A screenshot of a web browser showing the CFPB's consumer complaint page. The address bar displays 'https://www.consumerfinance.gov/complaint/'. The page header is 'CONSUMER FINANCIAL PROTECTION BUREAU'. The main heading is 'Submit a complaint'. Below it, a paragraph states: 'We forward your complaint to the company and work to get a response. Companies have 15 days to respond.' A box titled 'Have these ready:' contains a list of requirements: 'The name of the company involved', 'Account or transaction details', 'Documents that support your complaint (PDF, JPG, PNG)', and 'Brief description of what happened, in your own words'. At the bottom left is a dark blue button labeled 'Start a new complaint →'. At the bottom right is a yellow button labeled 'CLICK HERE'.

Open your browser. Type **consumerfinance.gov/complaint** in the address bar. Press Enter. You should see the page above. Click the **Start a new complaint** button to begin.

IF THE PAGE LOOKS DIFFERENT

The CFPB occasionally updates its visual design. The structure of the complaint form stays the same. Look for "Submit a complaint" or "Start a new complaint" — that is your entry point regardless of styling.

2

CFPB STEP 2

SELECT THE PRODUCT.

For credit reporting issues, you want "Credit reporting or other personal consumer reports." This is almost always your starting point for any account, inquiry, or personal information dispute.

The screenshot shows a web browser window with the URL <https://www.consumerfinance.gov/complaint/process/>. The page header is "CONSUMER FINANCIAL PROTECTION BUREAU". The main heading is "What product or service is your complaint about?". Below this, it says "Choose the option that best matches your issue." and "Select one". There are five radio button options: "Checking or savings account", "Credit reporting or other personal consumer reports" (which is selected and highlighted with a blue bar and a yellow "SELECT THIS" button), "Debt collection", "Mortgage", and "Credit card or prepaid card". At the bottom, there is a "Continue →" button.

SPECIAL CASE • DEBT COLLECTION SEPARATELY

If your complaint is specifically about a collection agency's behavior — abusive contact, FDCPA violations, harassment — you may want to file under "Debt collection" instead, OR file two separate complaints (one for credit reporting, one for debt collection). The CFPB allows multiple complaints when multiple issues exist.



Click the radio button next to **Credit reporting or other personal consumer reports**. The button fills in. Then click **Continue** at the bottom of the page.

3

CFPB STEP 3

SELECT THE SPECIFIC ISSUE.

This is the most important screen. The CFPB will route your complaint based on what you select. Pick the option that most accurately describes the violation. For most kit users, "Incorrect information on your report" is the right choice.

The screenshot shows a web browser window with the URL <https://www.consumerfinance.gov/complaint/process/issue/>. The page header is "CONSUMER FINANCIAL PROTECTION BUREAU". The main heading is "What type of problem are you having?". There are six radio button options, with the first one, "Incorrect information on your report", selected and highlighted in blue. A yellow badge labeled "MOST COMMON" is next to this option. The other options are: "Problem with a credit reporting company's investigation into an existing problem", "Improper use of your report", "Problem getting your free annual credit report", "Credit monitoring or identity theft protection services", and "Unable to get your credit report or credit score". A blue "Continue →" button is at the bottom left.

<https://www.consumerfinance.gov/complaint/process/issue/>

CONSUMER FINANCIAL PROTECTION BUREAU

What type of problem are you having?

☒ Incorrect information on your report **MOST COMMON**

☐ Problem with a credit reporting company's investigation into an existing problem

☐ Improper use of your report

☐ Problem getting your free annual credit report

☐ Credit monitoring or identity theft protection services

☐ Unable to get your credit report or credit score

Continue →

01 WHICH ISSUE MATCHES YOUR PHASE 4-5 SITUATION

ACCOUNT INACCURATE, BALANCE WRONG, STATUS WRONG

→ Incorrect information on your report

BUREAU IGNORED YOUR DISPUTE • LETTER 13 TRIGGER

→ Problem with a credit reporting company's investigation into an existing problem

METHOD OF VERIFICATION NOT PRODUCED · LETTER 12 FOLLOW-UP

→ Problem with a credit reporting company's investigation into an existing problem

UNAUTHORIZED HARD INQUIRY · LETTER 19 TRIGGER

→ Improper use of your report

4

CFPB STEP 4

TELL YOUR STORY.

Name the company. Describe what happened in your own words. Be specific. Include dates, FCRA section numbers where you know them, and what you have already done to try to resolve it.

<https://www.consumerfinance.gov/complaint/process/company/>

CONSUMER FINANCIAL PROTECTION BUREAU

Which company is your complaint about?

Company name

Equifax

What happened?

Tell us in your own words. Include dates, account information, and what you have done to try to resolve it. Up to 6,000 characters.

On January 15, 2026, I sent a written dispute by certified mail to Equifax regarding inaccurate information being reported on my credit file. The certified mail was delivered on January 18, 2026 (USPS tracking number 9505 5000 0000 0000 0000 00). The dispute concerned account [Creditor Name, Account #XXXX-XXXX-XXXX-1234] which is being reported with an incorrect Date of First Delinquency. I provided documentation showing the actual DOFD differs from what is being reported, which directly affects the legal removal date under FCRA §605(a)(4). On February 22, 2026, more than 30 days after delivery, I had received no written response. I sent a follow-up letter on February 25, 2026 demanding the method of verification under FCRA §611(a)(7)...

Continue →

01 HOW TO WRITE THE "WHAT HAPPENED" SECTION

Use this 5-paragraph template. Adjust the specifics to your case. Stay factual. No emotional language. The complaint reviewer is looking for evidence of specific federal violations, not your frustration.

PARAGRAPH 1 • SETUP

State the date you sent your first dispute and what it concerned. Include the certified mail tracking number and the delivery date.

PARAGRAPH 2 · THE DISPUTE

Describe what was inaccurate. Cite the specific FCRA section if you know it. Mention what documentation you provided.

PARAGRAPH 3 · THE VIOLATION

Describe what the bureau or furnisher did or did not do. Failure to respond, "verified" without method of verification, ignoring follow-up letters.

PARAGRAPH 4 · THE ESCALATION PATTERN

List subsequent letters you sent, dates, tracking numbers, and outcomes. Show the full paper trail.

PARAGRAPH 5 · THE REMEDY REQUESTED

State what you want resolved: deletion, correction, written confirmation. Reference the FCRA sections that authorize the remedy.

5

CFPB STEP 5

UPLOAD YOUR SUPPORTING DOCUMENTS.

This is where your paper trail becomes evidence. Every letter, every receipt, every response — clearly named, in chronological order.

https://www.consumerfinance.gov/complaint/process/documents/

CONSUMER FINANCIAL PROTECTION BUREAU

Add documents to your complaint

Upload up to 25 files. Each file must be under 25 MB. Accepted formats: PDF, JPG, PNG, DOC, DOCX, TXT.

↑

Drag files here or click to browse

Maximum 25 files · 25 MB each

01_Letter11_Round1_dispute_2026-01-15.pdf

✓ Uploaded

02_certified_mail_receipt_2026-01-18.pdf

✓ Uploaded

03_bureau_verified_response_2026-02-15.pdf

✓ Uploaded

04_Letter12_MOV_demand_2026-02-22.pdf

✓ Uploaded

05_credit_report_disputed_account.pdf

✓ Uploaded

Continue →

01 RECOMMENDED UPLOAD ORDER

Number your files so they upload in chronological order. The CFPB reviewer reads them top to bottom.

- **01_Letter11_Round1_dispute_[date].pdf** — Your initial dispute letter
- **02_certified_mail_receipt_[date].pdf** — USPS tracking and delivery confirmation

- **03_bureau_response_[date].pdf** — Whatever they sent back, dated
- **04_Letter12_or_13_followup_[date].pdf** — Your follow-up
- **05_certified_mail_receipt_[date].pdf** — Delivery proof for follow-up
- **06_credit_report_excerpt.pdf** — The page from your report showing the disputed item
- **07_timeline_summary.pdf** — One-page timeline you create yourself

OPTIONAL BUT POWERFUL: A ONE-PAGE TIMELINE

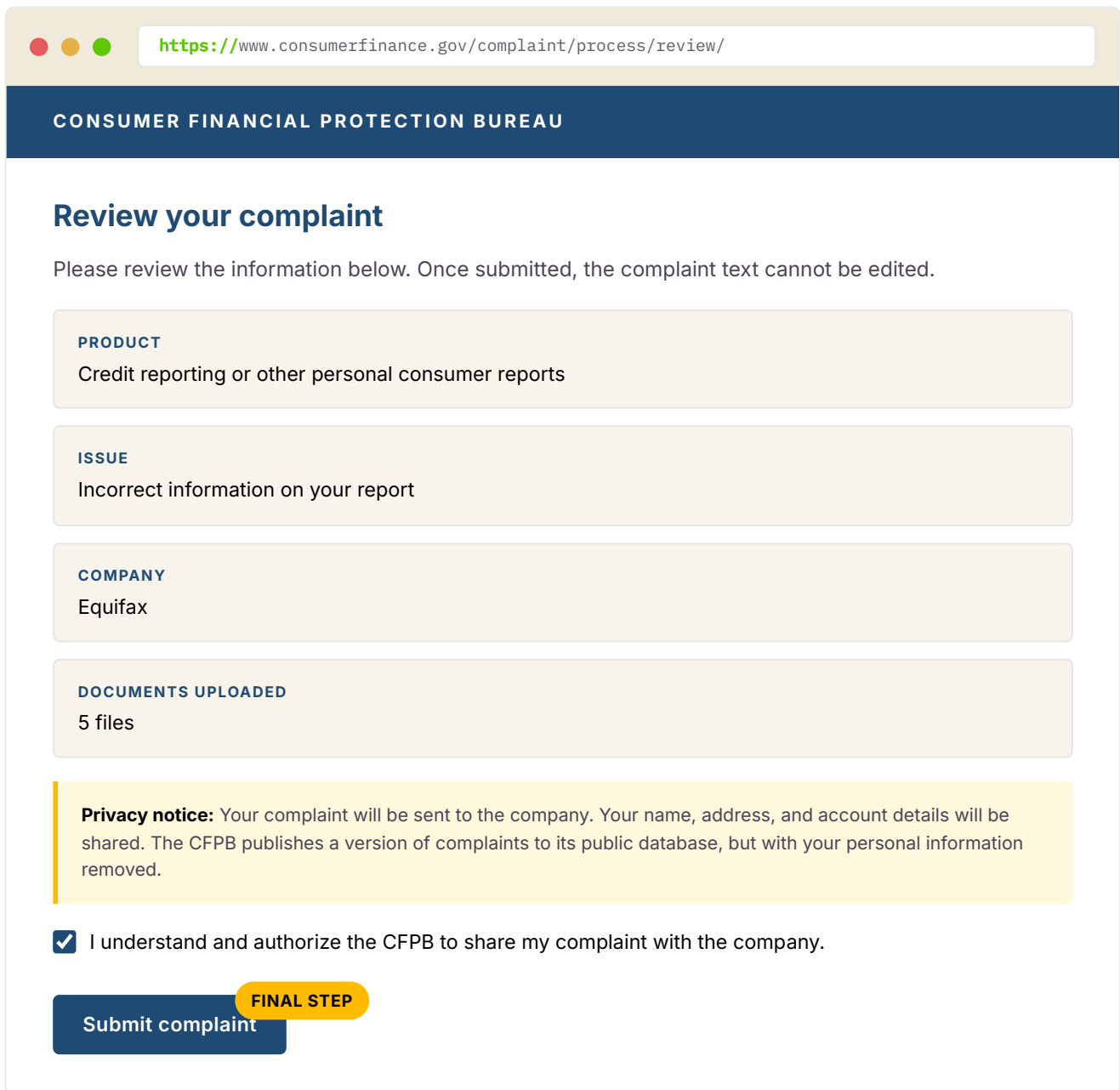
Create a single PDF that lists every date, every letter sent, every tracking number, every response. The complaint reviewer reads this first and uses it as their roadmap to your case. A clean timeline makes your complaint move faster.

6

CFPB STEP 6

REVIEW AND SUBMIT.

Last step. The CFPB will show you everything you entered. Read it slowly. Once you submit, you cannot edit. You can add documents and respond to company replies later, but you cannot change the original complaint text.

A screenshot of a web browser showing the CFPB complaint review page. The browser's address bar displays the URL: https://www.consumerfinance.gov/complaint/process/review/. The page has a dark blue header with the text "CONSUMER FINANCIAL PROTECTION BUREAU". Below the header, the main content area is titled "Review your complaint" in a bold, dark blue font. Underneath this title, a message states: "Please review the information below. Once submitted, the complaint text cannot be edited." The page features five light beige rectangular boxes, each containing a label in blue uppercase letters and a corresponding value. The first box is labeled "PRODUCT" and contains "Credit reporting or other personal consumer reports". The second box is labeled "ISSUE" and contains "Incorrect information on your report". The third box is labeled "COMPANY" and contains "Equifax". The fourth box is labeled "DOCUMENTS UPLOADED" and contains "5 files". Below these boxes is a yellow rectangular box containing a "Privacy notice" in bold, stating that the complaint will be sent to the company and that certain details will be shared with the public database. At the bottom of the form, there is a checkbox with a checkmark inside, followed by the text "I understand and authorize the CFPB to share my complaint with the company." To the right of this text is a yellow button labeled "FINAL STEP". Below the checkbox is a dark blue button labeled "Submit complaint".

https://www.consumerfinance.gov/complaint/process/review/

CONSUMER FINANCIAL PROTECTION BUREAU

Review your complaint

Please review the information below. Once submitted, the complaint text cannot be edited.

PRODUCT
Credit reporting or other personal consumer reports

ISSUE
Incorrect information on your report

COMPANY
Equifax

DOCUMENTS UPLOADED
5 files

Privacy notice: Your complaint will be sent to the company. Your name, address, and account details will be shared. The CFPB publishes a version of complaints to its public database, but with your personal information removed.

☒ I understand and authorize the CFPB to share my complaint with the company.

Submit complaint

FINAL STEP

YOU FILED. NOW WHAT.

Within 24 hours you receive a complaint number that looks like 26-XXXXXXX. Save it. Bookmark your CFPB account login page. The bureau or furnisher will respond through the CFPB portal within 15 days. You will

get an email when they do. Read their response. If you disagree, you can submit a follow-up directly through the portal.



PHASE 6 • BEYOND THE CFPB

FTC, STATE AG, AND ATTORNEY CONSULTATION.

When the CFPB complaint is not enough, or when the violation pattern is broad enough that you want pressure from multiple regulators at once.

01 FTC COMPLAINT • [REPORTFRAUD.FTC.GOV](https://reportfraud.ftc.gov)

The Federal Trade Commission does not investigate individual cases the way the CFPB does. What the FTC does is collect complaint data and use it to identify patterns that justify investigation or enforcement action against repeat-offender companies. Filing an FTC complaint adds your case to that pattern record.

- ❑ **Best for:** identity theft (use IdentityTheft.gov instead, which routes through the FTC), clear FDCPA violations by a debt collector, or pattern abuse by a furnisher.
- ❑ **What to file:** same documentation as your CFPB complaint. The FTC accepts the same evidence.
- ❑ **What to expect:** an acknowledgment, no individual case worker, no direct response on your case. Your complaint becomes part of FTC pattern data.

02 STATE ATTORNEY GENERAL

Your state Attorney General enforces both state and federal consumer protection law. State AGs often engage faster on cases within their jurisdiction than federal agencies do, and state laws sometimes give consumers stronger protections than federal law. Search for your state AG's consumer protection complaint form online.

- ❑ **Best for:** cases where the company has a physical presence in your state, or where state-specific consumer protection law applies (Texas DTPA, California Rosenthal Act, etc.).
- ❑ **What to file:** your full documentation file plus the CFPB complaint number if you have already filed.
- ❑ **What to expect:** an acknowledgment from the AG's consumer protection division. Some cases get individual review and direct outreach to the company. Others contribute to broader investigations.

03 CONSUMER RIGHTS ATTORNEY

FCRA cases are different from most legal matters. Under FCRA §616 and §617, the defendant pays the prevailing consumer's attorney fees on top of damages. Many consumer rights attorneys take FCRA cases on contingency, meaning no money out of your pocket. The free consultation is genuinely free, and they will tell you straight whether your case is strong.

What to bring to a consultation. The full paper trail. Every letter, every certified mail receipt, every response. A timeline document. Your CFPB complaint number if filed. Copies of your credit reports showing the disputed information. Specifically, screenshots or printed copies of every "verified" or non-response from a bureau or furnisher. The attorney will assess how clear the violation is and how much documented damage you can show.

- **How to find one:** the National Association of Consumer Advocates (consumeradvocates.org) maintains a directory by state.
- **Best for:** documented willful or repeated FCRA violations, situations where you have suffered measurable harm (denied credit, denied housing, denied employment) due to inaccurate reporting.
- **What to expect:** a phone or video consultation, an honest assessment of case strength, and either a contingency engagement or a referral to another resource.

ONE STEP AT A TIME

Most cases never need an attorney. The CFPB complaint resolves a meaningful share of cases that survived all five rounds. File CFPB first. Wait the 60 days. Then evaluate whether you still need additional escalation. Filing every channel at once is rarely the right move.



REFERENCE • THE ROUND TRACKER

TRACK EVERY ACCOUNT THROUGH EVERY ROUND.

Print as many copies as you have batches. One row per account. Fill in each cell as the round completes. The tracker is your evidence file in compact form.

ACCOUNT	ROUND 1		ROUND 2		ROUND 3		ROUND 4		ROUND 5		ESCALATION
NAME & TYPE	LETTER / DATE	RESPONSE	LETTER / DATE	RESPONSE	LETTER / DATE	RESPONSE	LETTER / DATE	RESPONSE	LETTER / DATE	RESPONSE	ACTION / DATE
Creditor: Type: Acct #:	L11 Date sent: _____	Result: _____	L12 Date sent: _____	Result: _____	L16/15 Date sent: _____	Result: _____	L15A/B Date sent: _____	Result: _____	L15C Date sent: _____	Result: _____	CFPB / FTC / AG / Atty: _____
Creditor: Type: Acct #:	L11 Date sent: _____	Result: _____	L12 Date sent: _____	Result: _____	L16/15 Date sent: _____	Result: _____	L15A/B Date sent: _____	Result: _____	L15C Date sent: _____	Result: _____	CFPB / FTC / AG / Atty: _____
Creditor: Type: Acct #:	L11 Date sent: _____	Result: _____	L12 Date sent: _____	Result: _____	L16/15 Date sent: _____	Result: _____	L15A/B Date sent: _____	Result: _____	L15C Date sent: _____	Result: _____	CFPB / FTC / AG / Atty: _____
Creditor: Type: Acct #:	L11 Date sent: _____	Result: _____	L12 Date sent: _____	Result: _____	L16/15 Date sent: _____	Result: _____	L15A/B Date sent: _____	Result: _____	L15C Date sent: _____	Result: _____	CFPB / FTC / AG / Atty: _____
Creditor: Type: Acct #:	L11 Date sent: _____	Result: _____	L12 Date sent: _____	Result: _____	L16/15 Date sent: _____	Result: _____	L15A/B Date sent: _____	Result: _____	L15C Date sent: _____	Result: _____	CFPB / FTC / AG / Atty: _____

RESULT CODES: DEL • Deleted VER • Verified UPD • Updated NR • No Response FRV • Marked Frivolous SET • Settled

A CLOSING WORD

For the one who finished.

If you are reading this page, you have walked the whole way through. That alone makes you different. Most people start. Few finish. The ones who finish know something the others did not.

You are not the score on a piece of paper. You never were. The score is data. You are a whole person, and you carry far more than what any bureau can quantify. Repairing your credit was never about becoming worthy. It was about correcting a record that was inaccurate, that was being weaponized, and that was holding back a life that was already valuable from the start.

Some accounts in this work will fall away quickly. Others will fight you for months. The fight is not personal. The system is built that way. What matters is that you stayed, and you stayed honest, and you let the law do its work the way it was written to.

" Credit education done right is a marathon paced like a hundred-meter dash. You move with intention every step. You do not stop, but you do not rush either. "

This Playbook is yours now. Print it. Mark it up. Pass copies to a Cousin who needs it. Pull it out again the next time the file gets bumpy. The system does not stop working when you put the book down. It is here whenever you need it.

I built this for you. I prayed over the structure of it before I wrote a word. I want the people who walk through it to be steadier on the other side. Not just with cleaner reports. Steadier. Calmer. More aware of their own legal protections. Better equipped to teach a friend.

If you took something useful from this work, the most meaningful thing you can do is finish for yourself first, then come back to help someone else finish too. That is how

the Cousin family grows.

Real credit education. Open door. Pull up a chair. I am proud of you.

Shonda Martin



CREDIT ACADEMY

EDUCATIONAL CONTENT ONLY

Shonda Martin and Credit Academy provide credit education, teaching, and self-help tools. Nothing in this Playbook is legal, financial, or tax advice, and no specific outcome is guaranteed.

Consumers can review their own reports, contact consumer reporting agencies and furnishers, and use federal consumer rights for free.

All FCRA and FDCPA references are accurate to publicly available federal statute as of the publication date of this edition. Consult an attorney for legal advice on your specific situation.

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